

Vertigo



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF AMANDA LOHREY

Amanda Lohrey was born in Hobart, Tasmania in 1947. While she was raised among working-class people and learned about unions from her family members (some of whom helped to run unions themselves), she was taught conflicting ideas at the Catholic school of her youth. Her experiences at Catholic school were mostly negative, fostering a distrust of women and authority figures that affected her for years afterwards. Even though Lohrey didn't feel a connection with Catholicism, she continued searching for a sense of spirituality and deeper connection to the world in her work. Many of her early works were essays and political writings, as she preferred to focus on a person's connection to the wider material world around them, rather than their individual, subjective experience. While this political theme runs through much of her work, Lohrey continues to experiment and defy expectations with her novels. After attending the University of Tasmania, she studied at Cambridge and later became a lecturer at the University of Technology in Sydney. Her writing has received several awards, including the Miles Franklin Award and the Voss Literary Prize. Today, she lives in Tasmania with her husband Andrew and continues writing in the Australian National University School of Literature, Languages, and Linguistics.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Luke and Anna's first encounter with the history of the area is their discovery of a colonial fort surrounding an old house near their new home. The crumbling structure is a remnant of Great Britain's colonization of Australia starting in 1788 with the establishment of a penal colony in Botany Bay. As for more recent history, *Vertigo* takes place (and was written) during the war in Afghanistan, which began in 2001 shortly after the September 11th terrorist attacks in the United States. While the conflict itself is distant from Australia, the country's participation in the war is felt by the novel's characters. Gil has a grandson participating in the war, and Gil is afraid to mention it for fear that the conflict will claim his grandson's life. Meanwhile, Luke becomes interested in the history of Palestine after watching a bombing on the news. He's surprised to read about how apparently uneventful the Middle East was in the early 20th century, at least according to the British surgeon Sir Frederick Treves. One other historical event that may have influenced the novel is the financial crisis of 2007-2008. While this great recession didn't affect Australia as severely as other countries like the United States, its effects were felt across the world. Anna's financial worries about her and Luke's apartment

in the city at the beginning of the novel might be informed by this wider crisis.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The tiny coastal town of Garra Nalla is the main setting of *Vertigo*, but Garra Nalla also features in *The Labyrinth*, one of Lohrey's more recent novels. *The Labyrinth* deals with similar themes, as the main character (Erica Marsden) flees to the coast to escape an upsetting event that happened to her back in the city. Erica's experiences in Garra Nalla flesh out the small town even further, letting the reader see it from the perspective of a new character in a similar situation. Meanwhile, for *Vertigo* itself, Lohrey mentions in an author's note that she was inspired by Henry Lawson's poem "The Fire at Ross's Farm." The poem describes two bitterly feuding families who constantly argue over the area's farmland. On Christmas Eve, a bushfire threatens to overrun one of the family's farms, and the ordeal eventually brings the clans together to fight back the blaze. Lawson's description of the fire resembles the firestorm in *Vertigo*, and the two families joining forces echoes how the citizens of Garra Nalla come together to help each other through the disaster. Lohrey also reused some of the names in the poem to flesh out the history of Garra Nalla. Readers interested in the themes of *Vertigo* might also enjoy [Cloudstreet](#), a novel by Tim Winton, another Australian author. [Cloudstreet](#) follows two families who've both experienced serious traumas, including the loss of a young boy. The novel details their attempts to deal with their grief and make a new life for themselves in a strange new place.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Vertigo*
- **When Written:** 2009
- **Where Written:** Australia
- **When Published:** May 4th, 2009
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novella
- **Setting:** Garra Nalla, a small, fictional town on Australia's coast
- **Climax:** A raging bushfire threatens to destroy the town of Garra Nalla, forcing Luke, Anna, and the other townsfolk to flee from their homes.
- **Antagonist:** The novella has no traditional antagonist. The protagonists are in conflict with nature, the elements, and the trauma of their past.
- **Point of View:** Third Person Omniscient

EXTRA CREDIT

Rings a Bell. Alan Watts, one of Luke and Anna's neighbors in Vertigo, is also the name of a famous philosophical writer. It's possible that Lohrey is referencing the real Alan Watts with her character, though it's also likely that this is just an interesting coincidence.



PLOT SUMMARY

Luke and Anna are a married couple living in a city in Australia. Their life isn't terrible by any means, but both of them have begun to feel a sense of growing emptiness and dissatisfaction with their lives. Luke feels as though he's lost his youth and purpose in life, while Anna becomes despondent after being diagnosed with asthma, which interferes with her usually active lifestyle. As he watches his wife struggle to breathe in bed with him one evening, Luke decides that a serious change is necessary. He suggests that the two of them pack their things and move to a more rural area, where they can both work from home. Anna is on board with the idea, though their parents are more skeptical. Nonetheless, they begin researching and scouting for the perfect rural town to move into. They already feel freer as they drive out on the open road to take a look at the towns they've researched. They're also delighted to look in the backseat and see their young boy sitting there, gazing out the windows curiously at the new places. Eventually, they accidentally find themselves in a tiny coastal town called Garra Nalla. The area looks beautiful and (more importantly) free of tourists due to the dangerous riptides. Thinking it's perfect for them, the couple decides to move to Garra Nalla.

As they settle into their new house in Garra Nalla, Luke and Anna enjoy how simple and homey the place feels, especially when compared to their small, drab apartment in the city. They also get acquainted with Gil, one of their new neighbors. Gil is a friendly old widower who welcomes the couple into the community as he gives them advice and shares his knowledge of the area. Luke takes up a new interest in watching and identifying the local **birds**, and the couple plant a garden in their yard. The boy seems happy to be in this new place; Luke and Anna admire the way he runs across the house's veranda and plays around in the garden. One evening, while coming home from a walk, Luke encounters a strange, owl-like bird that stares at him as he stares back. This experience makes Luke feel connected to nature and happy in a way he can't explain; he only wishes the boy could have been there with him to see the bird as well. Luke and Anna soon meet more friendly denizens of Garra Nalla: the Watts family. Alan Watts, his wife Bette, and their two children welcome the couple into their home, and they begin to play tennis together regularly. Luke and Anna also begin canoeing on Garra Nalla's large lagoon, bringing the boy with them (though he seems afraid of the swans).

Despite the joys of their new home, Luke and Anna's lives aren't perfect. Garra Nalla is in a very dry area, prone to drought, and the couple is forced to conserve water as much as possible. The area is also plagued by strong winds that continue day and night for weeks on end. The noise and the dryness of the wind begin to seriously get on Anna's nerves, especially as she becomes annoyed at Luke's indifference to the weather. When Luke's father Ken comes to visit one week, he wonders how Luke could possibly want to live in such a wild place, cut off from the conveniences of civilization. Luke is silently annoyed by his father's doubts, and Ken vaguely asks how Anna's been dealing with "that business," referring to something he doesn't want to mention directly. In the following weeks, the wind becomes too much for Anna, to the point where she tries casually telling Luke that she couldn't live in Garra Nalla her whole life. Luke takes the hint and suggests that they take a break and visit the city. Anna agrees, though Luke doesn't stay in the city long; he already misses the natural beauty and privacy of Garra Nalla. Anna stays behind in the city for a few more days, enjoying the lack of dryness but still not feeling at home. She realizes, sadly, that she hasn't seen the boy in quite a while, and she wonders why the boy always seems to take his father's side in everything.

After Anna returns home from the city, she and Luke plant the weeping she-oaks that Anna purchased, despite Gil's warnings about the plants being highly flammable. After celebrating the new additions to the garden with Gil and the Watts, Luke and Anna fall asleep on the veranda, only to wake up and see a smoky sky later that day. A large bushfire has started in the hills, and Garra Nalla soon becomes smothered by the smoke drifting in from the distant blaze. The locals insist that fires never reach the coast, but Luke and Anna still find themselves feeling mildly anxious as they hunker down in their sweltering house. Their concerns intensify as the bushfire grows ever closer, and Anna continues to wonder why she hasn't seen the boy in such a long time. She begins to worry that he's abandoned them, and worries that maybe the fire will claim their house; maybe they'll never find a real home. Later on, after the fire has taken out Garra Nalla's electricity, Luke and Anna join the townsfolk as they gather together to watch the approaching flames. For a moment, it seems as though the wind is changing in their favor, and that the fire might spare them. But just as they begin to let their guard down, Bette points out a churning, dark cloud of smoke and flame that none of them noticed before. The cloud throws a fireball into the town, and the denizens of Garra Nalla scatter in panic.

As the smoke and flames of a perfect firestorm begin to engulf Garra Nalla, the Watts run for the safety of the coast while Luke and Anna rush back to their house to put on wool clothing. Fire begins to consume the garden just as they begin to leave, seeming to trap them in the house with no safe escape route. Just then, a fire truck backs into their yard and firemen rescue

the couple, taking them to the relative safety of the lagoon, where many of the townsfolk have gathered. Soon enough, policemen inform the frightened townspeople that Garra Nalla is a crime scene (somehow, arson is suspected) and that everyone will be given food and a place to spend the night at a nearby church. On a mattress on the floor of the church's hall that night, Anna is relieved to find that the boy has returned to her. She drifts off into an exhausted sleep with the boy cradled lovingly in her arms. The next morning, a police officer tells the townsfolk that the fire has miraculously failed to burn Garra Nalla to cinders. Almost all of the houses remain intact, and there were no casualties.

Luke and Anna return to their house, relieved to find that it hasn't burned down. However, Luke becomes surprisingly upset when he sees that, during the fire, a bird has flown into their chimney and died on the floor; the same owl-like bird he saw before. Later that evening, he walks among the ashes and cinders where the bushfire burned the most furiously. The bleak sights around him force his memory back to a terrible day in the hospital: the day that Anna had a miscarriage. "The boy" was never a real child. He was only a phantom that Luke and Anna imagined; an image of the child they wished they'd had. Luke comes home later that night, crying in front of Anna for the first time. As they meet in the doorway, they both know what he's really crying about, and they embrace as they think of the boy they never really had. Anna weeps that night in bed as she finally faces her grief and dreams of the boy disappearing before her eyes. Days later, the Watts family hosts a large picnic to celebrate the town's survival. Anna and Luke attend, and Anna sees the boy out in a canoe on the lagoon, paddling away. She feels prepared to let him go, and to give herself a chance to live again. She waves goodbye to the boy and thanks him for staying with them for so long. That night, Luke dreams of the owl-like bird while Anna stays up and watches the news, seemingly content.

relationship. Anna never talks about the miscarriage, but this is exactly why she struggles to grow as a character until the end of the novel. All of Anna's physical struggles against nature—from the relentless wind to the raging bushfire—serve to push Anna to her emotional limits and force her to face her grief. Until that point, she's emotionally attached to an imaginary projection of the child she never had: a sort of ghost she calls "the boy." But ultimately, Anna's journey leads her to a point where she can finally let the boy go and accept that he's gone. Anna is a complex character who embodies both the subtle, quiet side of grief, and the surprising circumstances that can cause a person to change, grow, and move on.

Luke Worley – Luke Worley is the secondary protagonist of the novel, Anna Worley's husband, and Ken's son. When Luke sees his wife becoming physically weak and emotionally drained, he decides that the two of them should move from their small apartment in the city to a spacious new home in the country. This is the first indication of Luke's major function as a character: he's a constant catalyst for change in Anna's life. He sets the novel's events in motion by suggesting that the couple should move to a rural area. He causes Anna to question how much control she has over her life, as his personality seems to change in their new home. And most importantly, he openly shares in Anna's grief towards the end of the novel. Like Anna, Luke struggles to face the reality of Anna's recent miscarriage. He sees the imaginary child they could have had as a hallucination simply called "the boy," just like Anna does. But ultimately, Luke is the one who reckons with his grief first, as he walks among the ashes left in the wake of a bushfire. If Luke hadn't come home weeping that night and reminded Anna of the boy, it's possible that she might have never faced her own grief and moved on. While Luke spurs change in Anna's life, he also undergoes plenty of his own changes, mirroring his wife's character growth. His new interest in **bird**-watching is unusual for him, and he turns out to be much more "practical" than Anna expected, after the two of them settle into country life. Even though he's usually the character who sets new things in motion, Luke's own capacity to change still surprises him.

The Boy – The boy is a ghostly child, imagined or hallucinated by Luke and Anna throughout the novel. This character is more symbolic than literal, as he represents Anna's unborn child. After Anna's miscarriage prior to the novel's events, a counsellor asked Luke and Anna if they wanted to name their child who hadn't survived the birth. They agreed that they should name him, as it felt like a good thing to do, but they eventually decided to simply call him "the boy." This name felt more personal and intimate than any other name they could have given him. While the boy seems like a real child at the beginning of the novel, it gradually becomes clear that he's only an imaginary projection of the child Luke and Anna wish they could have had. The boy is a persistent presence in their lives, defined only by the sights and sounds he seems to add to their



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Anna Worley – Anna Worley is the main protagonist of the novel, and Luke Worley's wife. She lives with Luke in the city, where she begins to feel weak, despondent, and jealous of her wealthier friends. When Luke suggests that the two of them pack up and move to the country, Anna is eager to leave the city behind. The rest of the novel follows her experiences living in the tiny coastal town of Garra Nalla, where she tries to make a new life for herself and leave the past behind her. The narration explores Anna's thoughts and feelings more than those of any other character, even Luke. This is because most of the novel's conflicts are defined by a traumatic event in Anna's past: her miscarriage. The weight of Luke and Anna's grief over their unborn child is a constant tension in the background of their

world. He's nothing more than the noise he makes rattling a stick across the veranda, a glimpse of him playing in the garden, or the feeling of his sleeping body pressed against Anna's. But all of these sensations are illusions, created by the couple's unwillingness to face their grief and move on. They want to believe that their boy is still with them in some way, but they can only find peace when they mourn him and accept that he's gone. The boy is a manifestation of *Vertigo's* central conflict—a sign that something isn't quite right and needs to be put to rest.

Ken – Ken Worley is Luke's father. Ken's cynical attitude puts him at odds with Luke, who wants to believe that moving to the country was the right decision. During Ken's visit to his son's new home in the small, rural town of Garra Nalla, Ken is skeptical of country life. Luke doesn't argue with Ken about this, but their conversation reinforces the novel's tension between nature and civilization. Ken also sheepishly brings up "that business" with Luke's wife Anna, which serves as the first major hint that she might have had a miscarriage. Ken doesn't appear much in the novel, but his presence always tightens the dramatic tension and introduces doubt into the situation.

Gil – Gilbert Reilly (usually called Gil) is an elderly widower and a neighbor of Luke and Anna. Gil quickly befriends Luke and Anna after they move to the small coastal town of Garra Nalla. He offers advice, explains the lore of the area, and surprises Luke and Anna with how laid-back and accepting he is for a man of his age. With his helpful attitude and friendly demeanor, he makes the couple feel more welcome in their new home. While this makes him a hopeful sign that Luke and Anna's lives can get better, Gil harbors a quiet sadness of his own. Luke is surprised to learn that Gil has a grandson serving in the war in Afghanistan, and that Gil never talks about it. This is a direct parallel to Luke and Anna, who hesitate to talk about Anna's miscarriage and the child they never had.

Alan – Alan Watts is Bette's husband and the father of Zack and Briony. Alan and his family live in Garra Nalla and befriend Luke and Anna a few months after the couple moves into town. While Alan works as a math teacher, he also enjoys a physically active lifestyle of fishing, surfing, tennis, and practical projects. During a firestorm that rages through Garra Nalla, Alan comes close to losing his children. The experience leaves him deeply shaken and grateful that his family survived the ordeal.

Bette – Bette Watts is Alan's wife and the mother of Zack and Briony. She and her family live in Garra Nalla and become friends with Luke and Anna, welcoming them into the town's community. Bette is a nurse, and she shares in her husband's active lifestyle. While Bette is more reserved than Alan, her sudden question about starting a family makes Anna pause in thought. Anna's dismissive answer to Bette's question is an early clue that Anna's "boy" isn't what he seems.

Rodney – Rodney Banfield is a plumber and one of Luke and Anna's neighbors in Garra Nalla. Rodney's presence in the

couple's lives is minimal, but his childish conversation with Luke makes Anna feel like her husband is changing too much and slipping away from her. Rumors persist that Rodney is having an affair with a local miner's wife.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Zack and Briony – Zack and Briony Watts are the energetic children of Alan and Bette. During the bushfire that threatens their home in Garra Nalla, the children follow their father down to the beach, where they're almost swept away by the tides.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



GRIEF AND LOSS

Though it often appears indirectly, grief is a constant presence in the lives of Luke and Anna. By always keeping the pain of their loss present but never quite in focus, *Vertigo* explores a quiet, subtle side of grief that lingers in the background of the characters' thoughts. This view of grief is expressed through the character known simply as "the boy." The boy is a child that exists only in Luke's and Anna's imagination, following Anna's miscarriage prior to the novel's events. This ghost-like child represents the heavy burden of grief that the couple still carries but hesitates to acknowledge directly. As the boy appears at various points in their lives, he shows them a glimpse of what could have been: the seemingly perfect life that they almost had but that was tragically snatched away from them.

In this way, *Vertigo* highlights grief's ability to subtly linger. Just as grief can drive a person into more intense and dramatic episodes of sadness, it can also slowly, quietly erode someone's emotions until there's almost nothing left. The underlying tension in Luke and Anna's relationship is largely a result of this kind of grief. Because they're unwilling to directly face the pain of their loss, it seeps into their everyday world in the form of their visions of the boy, who is hovering between worlds just like they are. Ultimately, however, the novel settles on a hopeful message of coming to terms with grief and—in doing so—putting it to rest. After the harrowing bushfire pushes Luke and Anna to their emotional limits, they're forced to accept that their unborn child is gone forever. Only after they come to terms with their loss can they finally find peace, let the boy go, and move on with their lives.



NATURE VS. URBAN LIFE

The novel's constant comparison of city life and rural life hints at a broader contrast between untamed nature and the structured quality of an urban existence. As this juxtaposition plays out, the novel suggests that the benefits of living in nature are worth the struggles and hardships that come with a more rugged lifestyle. However, *Vertigo* treats this theme with plenty of nuance, leaving room for interpretation. At the beginning of the novel, Luke and Anna are dissatisfied with city life and thrilled to move to the tiny town of Garra Nalla, which feels raw and untamed. The couple has many positive experiences in the natural beauty of Garra Nalla, including a new interest in **birdwatching** and canoeing on the lagoon. Their new neighbor Gil reinforces their love for the natural world, as he shows them the landscape and rails against the consortium of businessmen who aim to pollute the area.

At the same time, living in the wild country presents its own problems, such as relentless wind, drought, and the bushfire that almost destroys what little civilization exists in Garra Nalla. Anna enjoys her brief visit to the city and even appreciates its urban beauty, constantly wondering if she and Luke really moved to the right place. But in the end, nature wins out over urban life, at least for Luke and Anna. The rough, natural world of Garra Nalla gives the couple the space and privacy to reflect, grieve, and start a new life for themselves.



CHANGE AND PERSONAL GROWTH

At the beginning of the novel, Anna and Luke are in desperate need of a change. The rest of their story is an exploration of what their lives might become and, on a broader level, whether change is even possible at all. This focus on change begins with the first line of the novel, which mentions Luke's new and surprising interest in **birdwatching**. Luke continues to develop as a person after he and Anna move to the coast, to the point where Anna feels she hardly recognizes him anymore. He proves himself to be more practical than she expected, but she also comes find him duller than she would have thought she'd find him. In this way, their new life and its promise of change becomes a double-edged sword. Luke and Anna feel more refreshed and alive in their new home on the coast, but they're also changed by the new environment and its challenges.

Nonetheless, these challenges give Luke and Anna an opportunity to grow as people and change for the better. Anna's garden is symbolic of this personal growth and her desire to start something new. Even as a bushfire razes the garden to the ground, hope remains in the form of Anna's fire-resistant she-oaks. Similarly, the same bushfire indirectly leads to the novel's most important moment of personal growth: Luke and Anna putting the memory of their unborn child to

rest. However, even after this significant positive change, *Vertigo* still ends on an ironic note, as Anna starts watching the news, which is an old habit of hers. The novel thus opens with Luke changing his usual behavior but ends with Anna doing something she's done since she was young. This implies that even if personal growth is possible, some things might never change.



COMMUNITY

Luke and Anna move to the small town of Garra Nalla specifically because it doesn't have many people, but they nonetheless find and embrace a new community there. By showing how everyone in Garra Nalla is stronger for supporting each other, *Vertigo* casts the importance of community in a positive light. Anna and Luke's first encounter with their new community is through their neighbor Gil, who acts as their guide and the first friend they make in Garra Nalla. Gil is the character who reinforces the theme of community the most directly. This is especially evident when he tells the couple about the consortium of businessmen who own an old mansion in the area. The consortium uses the mansion for occasional parties, but they don't have any real connection to Garra Nalla or its people. This makes them worthy of contempt in Gil's view, as mere proximity doesn't make them part of the community.

Meanwhile, Alan and Bette also welcome Luke and Anna into Garra Nalla's social circle. Bette's questions about starting a family force Anna to think about her own unborn child in a way she has tried to avoid. In this way, exposure to a community of friends is healthy for her, even if it sometimes makes her uncomfortable. The most significant moment of the town's community strengthening one another comes in the third chapter, during the massive bushfire. The flames nearly consume the town, but because the community of Garra Nalla pulls together to help their neighbors, the disaster doesn't claim any lives. The promise of solitude is what initially attracted Luke and Anna to Garra Nalla—but ironically, the town's community is what makes them feel truly welcome there by the end of the novel.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



BIRDS

Luke and Anna's time in Garra Nalla is defined in part by the local birds, a symbol of new life and the possibility of change. The novel opens with an explanation of Luke's new and surprising interest in bird-watching. This immediately establishes a link between birds and the novel's

themes of change and personal growth. The trend continues when Luke and Anna begin bird-watching together shortly after moving out of the city. They're excited and proud to learn to identify the local bird species, as it makes them feel like they truly belong in their new, rural home. In other words, the birds have become a symbol of positive change in their lives. Possibly the most significant example of this idea is the strange, owl-like bird that Luke encounters on his way home from a walk one evening. The bird stares at him while he stares back, and this experience fills him with a sense of awe and unexpected happiness.

But these feelings are turned on their head towards the end of the novel, when Luke finds the same bird dead on his floor. He's surprisingly upset over this discovery, but it's not really the bird he's mourning. The sight of the dead bird reminds Luke of Anna's miscarriage not long ago. If the local birds represent positive change, the dead owl-like bird embodies a potential change that was thwarted and never came to pass. However, the sight of this bird forces Luke to face the feelings he's been trying to avoid. This ultimately causes the most important change in the novel: Luke and Anna coming to terms with their grief over the miscarriage. The unexpected return of the swans in the lagoon at the end of the novel reflects the couple's newfound sense of peace. As the swans return, the novel's symbolism implies that Luke and Anna have finally changed for the better.

seemingly minor observation, the novel introduces one of its central ideas: that people have the capacity to change, possibly for the better. This change in Luke's habits comes up before the reader learns anything else about Luke as a character, which puts emphasis on what's changing about him rather than on what came before.

The mention of birdwatching also subtly introduces the novel's theme of nature vs. urban life. Whatever change has happened to Luke, it seems to be bringing him closer to the natural world. This provides a clue for what sort of changes are likely to affect the characters later in the novel, and what might spur them to grow and develop into something new. Luke's new birdwatching habit is an early sign that it's nature (rather than urban life) that holds the potential for positive change in his life.

☞ When she was in her twenties Anna had thought of herself as a bohemian, a free spirit who was serious about the right things and carefree about the rest, but now she was turning into some other woman, a woman on the edge of becoming anxiously acquisitive.

Related Characters: Anna Worley

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 8

Explanation and Analysis

Despite their relatively comfortable life in the city, Anna and her husband Luke begin to feel themselves wasting away and needing something new. Anna's self-reflection here reinforces the theme of change, but it shows the more negative side of growth and personal development. Anna can feel herself changing, but she knows she's "turning into" something she doesn't want to be—a worse person than she was before. The use of the word "bohemian" highlights how Anna feels about herself in this moment. Where a bohemian lives unconventionally and free of social expectations, Anna feels that she's losing her freedom as her life becomes too predictable.

At the same time, this description of a negative change also implies the possibility of a positive change later on. If Anna can become a worse person by staying in her current environment, a change of scenery could change her for the better. Fortunately for Anna, she only feels as though she's in a transitional phase at this point in the novel. She's just "on the edge" of a transformation, and she still has time to



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Black Inc. edition of *Vertigo* published in 2009.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ But now, at the age of thirty-four, he has taken to bird-watching. It's true he might once have laughed at this, but since then much has changed.

Related Characters: Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 3

Explanation and Analysis

This first passage of the novel immediately establishes the theme of change and personal growth. Even from his own point of view, Luke's birdwatching behavior is strange and seemingly out-of-character. By beginning with this

improve her situation and grow into the kind of person she wants to be.

“But there’s nothing here!” their friends would exclaim when later they came to visit. No shops, no hotel, no community hall, no boat ramp or barbecue area. And this was true, and it was the reason they had chosen the place. They felt that in some essential way it was uncultivated, a landscape out of time, and as such it could not define them. Here they could live, and simply be.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

While looking for a new home in a rural area, Luke and Anna accidentally stumble on the tiny coastal settlement of Garra Nalla, which seems perfect for them. It’s notable that Garra Nalla is attractive to the couple because of its stark differences to urban life: there are no crowds, no attractions, and nothing that can “define them” in a way they’re uncomfortable with. This further helps to introduce the novel’s theme of nature vs. civilization, as escaping from the city to the countryside appears to be exactly what Luke and Anna need to improve their lives.

However, it’s ironic that the couple chooses Garra Nalla for its lack of people. While it makes sense that they want to avoid crowds so that their new home feels as different from the city as possible, their new connections with the people of Garra Nalla will soon become deeply important to them. Despite the town having “no community hall,” Luke and Anna still feel welcomed by Garra Nalla’s small community. The city has far more people, but in a more rural and “wild” place like Garra Nalla, the connections between people can feel stronger as they form a tighter and more meaningful community. This highlights an interesting angle of the novel’s theme of community: it’s not that Luke and Anna want to avoid people in general—it’s that they want to avoid people whom they don’t really know.

“Often the boy appears to play alongside them, whirling around in the dust or darting mischievously among the weed piles and throwing clumps of weeds into the air. Sometimes he sings snatches of nursery songs in a thin, childish lilt that is charmingly off-key. At such times his parents do not look one another in the eye; the weighty joy of it would be too much.”

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 24

Explanation and Analysis

After moving into their new home and starting a garden, Luke and Anna are quietly happy to see their boy playing in the yard. Later in the novel, however, it’s revealed that the boy is only in their imagination—a phantom of the child they never really had. This paints the scene in a tragic new light, as the couple is only picturing what their unborn child might have been like if Anna’s miscarriage had not occurred. At this point in the novel, moments like these are how Luke and Anna respond to their grief. Rather than facing their loss directly, they imagine what could have been if things had gone differently.

Another significant point is the moment when Luke and Anna stop themselves from looking at each other. The narration mentions that they’d be too overjoyed to look eyes as they “hear” the boy playing, but the true implication is much more tragic. If Luke and Anna looked at each other in this moment, it seems more likely that they’d have to face their grief head-on and acknowledge it to each other. They want to avoid this, as it’s really the pain of their loss that “would be too much.”

“There is no time: time is a loop of endless return, a return to this moment, which is not strange but a coming home, and it does not occur to him to ask where this home is because he is simply there, he is in it; this silent space of euphoric emptiness. And for the rest of his walk home he is elated. He has never been happier; pointlessly, mindlessly happy.”

Related Characters: Luke Worley

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

On his way home from a walk one evening, Luke spots a strange, owl-like bird that stares at him as he stares back. They share an odd moment of timelessness as they watch each other, and the experience makes Luke feel inexplicably content. This encounter is one example of birds representing the possibility of positive change in the lives of Luke and Anna. While Luke can't explain why the owl-like bird makes him so happy, it does demonstrate how a person's attitude can change in strange and unexpected ways.

On the surface, this sudden change in Luke seems like a positive one. However, the description of this moment adds a layer of complication. Luke isn't just happy; he's "pointlessly, mindlessly happy," and his feeling is one of "euphoric emptiness." This implies that the changes affecting Luke might be pleasant, but they're also making him less sharp, as if they're numbing his mind or making him drunk. The trend continues in the second chapter, when Anna begins to feel that Luke is becoming less quick-witted and more childish. In this way, the strange bird marks the arrival of a change, but also highlights the possibility that not every change will be a healthy one.

☞ He dreams of a tidal wave that sweeps in from the ocean and submerges the settlement in a depth of clear green water. But this isn't a nightmare; it's a benign dream, a dream in which he swims beneath the sunlit surface like a water baby. And the boy is there, swimming alongside. His face is radiant and there are small translucent fish darting around his head; his golden curls stream behind him in unravelling coils of light while his small but supple limbs beat against the current.

Related Characters: Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 36-37

Explanation and Analysis

Some time after moving to the small town of Garra Nalla, Luke starts having recurring dreams of the sea consuming the town. The presence of the boy in this dream is an early clue that he's more than what he seems. His appearance is almost angelic as he swims alongside Luke, giving the boy an otherworldly quality. This makes more sense with the later

revelation that the boy only exists in Luke and Anna's imagination. Because the boy is an imaginary representation of the couple's unborn son, Luke sees him as a perfect, ideal child, especially in this dream. The dream is just one more way that Luke's grief over Anna's miscarriage manifests itself.

The flooding in the dream is also significant, as it reinforces the novel's ongoing conflict between nature and civilization. Now that he lives in a wild and mostly unpopulated area, Luke might feel less important, as though he could be swept away by the elements at any time and nothing would change. In the context of this dream, however, this sense of insignificance is more of a comfort than an anxiety. Luke's dream could also be considered foreshadowing, as the town will soon be threatened by an overwhelming natural disaster. But ironically, it's fire, not water, that will menace the town. The fire's destruction eventually leads to Luke coming to terms with his grief, rather than numbing the pain as he does in this dream.

☞ A sign of the times, he thinks; olives, vineyards, walnut farms. The old-style selectors are gone and change is everywhere, and now he and Anna are a part of it. And with this encouraging thought he puts down his book and walks to the window where the blinds remain furled and big cigar moths beat against the glass. Only the stars at night seem fixed in their station, and this, too, he knows is an illusion.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 42

Explanation and Analysis

Luke reflects on the changes that have affected his life and the world around him. His life seems to be improving ever since he moved to the rural town of Garra Nalla with his wife Anna, and he begins to think that constant change might be inevitable. Luke's observation about the stars synthesizes the novel's ideas about nature and change. Even though the stars appear to be stationary, he knows that he's only seeing their light from far away, and that the earth is always rotating. In other words, nature itself is always shifting and changing, even if it's nearly impossible to notice.

Luke makes his growing connection to nature even deeper when he realizes that he and his wife are a part of this constant change as well. Just as the two of them moved to

Garra Nalla to change their own lives, their presence here is changing the environment as well. This moment of clarity lets Luke reflect on the interconnectedness of everything, and the ongoing possibility of change for himself and Anna. The moths bumping against the window is one more bit of imagery that brings the conflict between nature and civilization into focus.

Chapter 2 Quotes

☛ Delighted to find that Luke and Anna can both hit a ball he invites them to play doubles on the weekends, and sometimes of an evening after work. Like all social tennis, it is played with an underlying ferocity, the men volleying at the net as though their life depends on it and swearing under their breath. Nor is Anna immune to this manic athleticism, even if there is something comically grim in the way that Alan barks out the score after every point.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley , Alan, Bette

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 50

Explanation and Analysis

This light and humorous moment highlights how much Luke and Anna have already changed for the better after such a short time living in Garra Nalla. Luke and Anna's tennis games with the Watts are a sign that the newcomers have been fully accepted into the town's community at this point. In the city, the Worley couple felt isolated and alienated from others despite the abundance of people around them. But now, in the smaller and more tightly knit community of Garra Nalla, they feel connected to their new friends in a meaningful way.

In Anna's case, it's also significant that she's bonding with others through physical exercise. Anna's asthma damaged her self-worth back in the city, as she felt she could no longer live the sort of active lifestyle she wanted for herself. But now, in the fresh air of Garra Nalla, she can more easily push herself to be physically (and socially) active. This demonstrates her ongoing character growth, which is drastically influenced by her environment. Anna still has a long way to go in terms of character development, but her new habit of tennis with the Watts is a promising sign of positive change in her life.

☛ Bette is not a shy woman but she has a natural reserve so Anna is surprised when she says, 'Do you think, Anna, that you'll ever start a family?' 'We've put that on hold,' says Anna, firmly. 'First we have to decide where home is.' This isn't the whole truth, far from it, and she hopes the boy isn't listening.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Bette (speaker), Luke Worley , The Boy

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 53

Explanation and Analysis

Bette, one of Anna's new friends in Garra Nalla, catches Anna off guard with a sudden question about whether Anna ever wants to have children. Anna's hesitant response is a major clue that "the boy" isn't real. After all, Bette wouldn't have asked this question if she had ever seen the boy herself. The boy is only a sort of hallucination in the minds of Luke and Anna, ever since Anna had a miscarriage a few years ago. While both Luke and Anna have tried to avoid thinking about this as they continue to imagine their son who never existed, this question from Bette forces Anna to focus on her grief for at least a moment.

This highlights how becoming part of a real community is pushing Anna towards making progress with her grief. If Luke and Anna had stayed isolated back in the city, they might have continued to suppress the pain of their loss indefinitely. But by joining the close community of Garra Nalla, Anna has meaningful conversations with others, which eventually leads her to acknowledge her grief directly. In this case, exposure to other people and their new ideas is one of the strongest benefits of joining a community.

☛ My God, he can't even name it, thinks Luke in a spasm of bitter scorn. Typical. His father never could deal with the messy human dimension of feeling. But then as he watches the spray foam up from the blowhole, for the first time it occurs to him that the 'other business' might have been painful for Ken, a man with no grandchildren.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley , Ken

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 55

Explanation and Analysis

When Luke's father Ken comes to visit, Ken asks Luke how Anna has been handling "that other business," a phrase meant to avoid mentioning a traumatic event by name. This event is heavily implied to be Anna's recent miscarriage, which the couple is still struggling to process. Ken's inability to mention the miscarriage directly is a sign that Luke and Anna's grief isn't unique to them. Even though they were the two people most affected by the tragic event, Ken was also seemingly hurt by their loss.

It's also worth noting that Luke's scorn for Ken in this moment is ironic—maybe even hypocritical. Luke is angry with his father for refusing to mention the miscarriage by name, but this is exactly what Luke himself has been doing throughout the novel. Neither he nor Anna ever talk about the son they never had; they only imagine he's with them and pretend to themselves that he survived the birth. It's possible that Luke's resentment in this moment is projection, as Luke might be aware that he's avoiding the pain of his grief just as much as Ken is.

☛ In the city the weather is just a backdrop to your day, a painted canvas against which you enact the plot of your life. In the country the weather *is* the plot.

Related Characters: Anna Worley

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 61-62

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly after moving from the city to rural Garra Nalla, Anna begins to feel anxious and stressed due to the area's relentless winds. This passage puts nature and civilization in stark contrast, as Anna struggles to adjust to her new life in a wilder and more untamed place. While she could usually ignore the weather back in the city, the weather in Garra Nalla defines her day, as there's much less separating her from the elements. Nature is often cast in a positive light throughout the novel, but this moment is a reminder that nature can be harsh and brutal, even as it helps Luke and Anna create a new life for themselves.

Anna's observation about the weather also becomes ironic in the context of why they moved to Garra Nalla in the first place. Luke and Anna felt that the city was shaping them and turning them into people they didn't want to become, so they moved to the coast to escape these social pressures. But in their new, rural home, they feel shaped and defined

by the natural environment rather than by the complications of city life. In this way, nature and civilization both have challenges and influences on Luke and Anna's lives. Neither is necessarily ideal, but the couple must choose one or the other, depending on which challenges they'd rather face.

☛ As time goes on the all-pervading squalor of his tour seems to induce in Sir Frederick an increasingly acid disillusionment. This dry, stony country, these wretched towns and villages, these gloomy basilicas and their fake relics; can this be the Promised Land?

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 65

Explanation and Analysis

In his spare time, Luke reads an old travelogue called *The Land That Is Desolate*, an account of Sir Frederick Treves's journey through the holy sites of the Middle East. As Treves searches for meaning and consolation after the death of his daughter, he seems to find nothing but disappointment in the sacred places he visits. The travels of Sir Frederick are a direct analogue to Luke and Anna's recent experiences with loss and a search for meaning. Like Treves, Luke and Anna have also recently lost a child, and now they're trying to create a new purpose for themselves by experiencing a new land.

Just as Sir Frederick is unimpressed by the "Promised Land," Luke and Anna encounter disappointments and complications in Garra Nalla, which they believed to be perfect for them. Nature is constantly and aggressively present in the form of constant wind, relentless drought, and occasional encounters with snakes. This sometimes makes the couple wonder if Garra Nalla can really be the right place for them to call home, just as Frederick is skeptical of the so-called Promised Land he travels through. Rather than finding a way to numb their grief, Luke, Anna, and Treves only seem to find more difficulties.

●● Alan is standing at the edge of the grassy path, beside the body of a dead swan. It appears to have flown into the wires overhead and been electrocuted, and not all that long ago since there is no sign of it having been set upon by crows. It's a deflating sight: the twisted black carcass, the slash of white feather down its middle, the broken neck splayed at a right angle, the crimson beak lying bright against the sandy stubble of the track.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy, Alan

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 69-70

Explanation and Analysis

Just after Luke thinks about his wife Anna's miscarriage for the first time in a while, Alan points out the grisly sight of a dead swan nearby. The conversation prior to this passage suddenly reminded Luke of the boy, an imaginary projection of Anna's unborn son. The sight of the dead swan punctuates this painful memory with yet another reminder of what has been lost. For most of the novel, Luke keeps his grief about the miscarriage in the back of his mind, letting it manifest as the imaginary boy who sometimes appears in his everyday life. But with an innocent creature dead in front of him, Luke is forced to momentarily face his grief instead of suppressing it.

The way in which the swan died also reinforces the theme of nature vs. civilization, by reminding Luke that even in a small, rural town like Garra Nalla, manmade creations can still harm nature. This moment also plays with the idea of birds as a symbol of change. If the local birds represent the possibility for Luke and Anna's lives to change for the better, a dead swan is a sign that maybe such change is impossible. No matter where they go or how they try to escape from their grief, nature itself will always remind them of the fragility of life, and of what they've already lost.

●● She loves the lurid metropolitan sunsets, and she cannot see how these flushed and burnished skies are inferior to what they look out on from the veranda at Garra Nalla; indeed, the dark, blockish shapes of the city skyline, the contrast of their sharp-edged silhouettes against a fiery sky, confer a on nature an even greater drama.

Related Characters: Anna Worley

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 75

Explanation and Analysis

Needing a break from the constant wind and dryness of their new home in Garra Nalla, Luke and Anna visit the city for a few days. Luke goes home early, but Anna stays behind and finds she's enjoying urban life again. Anna's reflections on the beauty of the city provides a new angle on the theme of nature vs. urban life. Rural life in Garra Nalla seems to be what Luke and Anna need most to make their lives better, but this moment highlights the more positive side of living in the city.

The passage also represents a rare moment in the novel in which nature and civilization seem to come together in harmony rather than oppose each other. The sharp lines of the city "confer" an extra layer of beauty to nature, implying that these two worlds don't always have to be at odds with each other. On the other hand, Anna's thoughts echo her earlier observation that the weather is only a backdrop in the city. Nature's beauty might be enhanced by the dramatic cityscape, but this doesn't necessarily mean that nature and civilization are in perfect balance here. In this context, the city might not be the perfect place for Anna to live, as she's still not fully connected to nature here.

●● Damn Luke, damn his stupid ideas. All he has succeeded in doing is creating a situation where she doesn't feel at home anywhere. Now she belongs in neither place, like some migratory bird that has lost its bearings. But the most disturbing thing is this: here in the city there has been no sign of the boy.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 75-76

Explanation and Analysis

After visiting the city for a while and feeling uncomfortable again, Anna curses Luke for having the idea to move to Garra Nalla in the first place. Anna's unease stems from her inability to settle the conflict between nature and

civilization. The wind and drought of the country constantly put her on edge, and while she's more comfortable in the city, the absence of the boy seems to bother her more than anything. While the boy is only a figment of her grief-ridden imagination, the fact that she doesn't see him in the city implies that her mind might be trying to tell her something.

The boy is a manifestation of Anna's grief over her recent miscarriage, so the boy's absence in this moment is telling. It likely means that she knows city life isn't for her, even if rural life presents its own challenges. Anna instinctively trusts the boy and wants to see him again, so her thoughts and emotions seem to be drawing her back to Garra Nalla, even if subconsciously. Notably, Anna is compared to a lost bird in this passage, which once again connects her with nature more than civilization. This also reinforces birds as a symbol of change. Anna still clearly needs a change in her life, but at this point, she can't decide what form that change should take.

☞ 'In the middle of a bloody drought!' fumes Gil. 'It'll be a fire hazard for one thing. And I'll tell you another thing. It'll suck up all the water out of the water table and eventually out of the lagoon. In five years' time that lagoon will be a bloody mudflat. Them swans'll have to find somewhere else to breed.'

Related Characters: Gil (speaker), Anna Worley, Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 80-81

Explanation and Analysis

Gil visits Luke and Anna to furiously explain that the consortium of businessmen who owns a mansion nearby is planning to start a large tree plantation in Garra Nalla. This will most likely pollute the area, ruining the natural beauty of the town. This troubling possibility takes the theme of nature vs. civilization in a new direction, as manmade pollution now threatens to invade a wild and natural place. For most of the novel, nature and civilization existed in two mostly separate worlds, and it was up to Luke and Anna to decide which they preferred. But with the threat of a new plantation looming, the couple feels that maybe they'll never be able to escape modern complications, no matter where they live.

Gil's anger towards the consortium also reflects the disconnect between the community of Garra Nalla and the outside world. Having lived and worked in the town for many years, Gil is intimately familiar with the area's fragile ecosystem, whereas the consortium seems to see Garra Nalla as nothing but another profitable development project. This outside interference threatens to ruin the community that Luke and Anna have only just become a part of. The possibility of the swans leaving Garra Nalla is a symbolic indication that the couple's hopes for a better life here might be fading.

☞ At any moment they could disappear from this place and nothing would change, nothing of consequence, so vast is this land and so small are they. And the thought of this brings on a rush of vertigo, a dizzying sense of disorientation, as if she is about to fall, but that when she falls she will be weightless. She has lost her roots, her anchorage to the earth; she might float away into the blue of the sky and never be heard from again.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

Anna has a moment of internal crisis one evening as she watches her husband Luke walk home and sees him in a new light, almost as a stranger. This moment gives the novel its title, as it engages with many themes at once. Anna feels overwhelmed partly because she still hasn't come to terms with the grief of her recent miscarriage, nor has she gotten used to living in the country instead of the city. Out in the wild expanse on the coast, it becomes easier for Anna to feel insignificant compared to the ever-present vastness of nature. This wasn't a problem when she was in a center of civilization, but now that she lives in a wilder place, her troubled inner thoughts have become much louder and harder to ignore.

Another reason why Anna feels like she's losing her grip on the world is her perception of Luke in this moment. Luke and Anna moved to Garra Nalla to change their lives for the better, but at this point, change becomes a deeply frightening possibility for Anna. She's been watching Luke act differently from how he normally acts, and she's afraid that he's becoming another person—not the man she married. Change and growth seem very possible in Garra Nalla, but no worthwhile change is without its scary and

uncomfortable moments like these. Without facing her grief directly, Anna might be unable to accept the changes in her life and move on while feeling grounded.

Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ It's a long time since she heard his stick clatter across the veranda, and now there is a fire burning on the rim of their world. Where are you? she asks. Is it something we've done, some oversight in our thoughts? Have we become too self-absorbed and careless? Have you decided, after all, to leave us?

Related Characters: Anna Worley, The Boy

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 95

Explanation and Analysis

As a raging bushfire slowly but surely approaches Garra Nalla, Anna silently addresses the boy, whom she hasn't seen in a long time. The boy is a phantom who only exists in Luke and Anna's imagination, following Anna's recent miscarriage. Because the boy is a representation of Anna's unborn child, her message to him in this moment reveals much about her mental state. Despite the fact that the boy usually appears to the couple sporadically and unpredictably, Anna still feels responsible for the fact that he hasn't been around lately.

This could mean that Anna still feels guilty about the miscarriage, even though it was a tragedy that was outside of her control. The boy is a vessel for Anna to process her feelings and numb the pain of her loss, so without him nearby, she feels lost and helpless. She might be blaming her own carelessness for his absence in an attempt to feel more in control of a situation that scares her. But ultimately, she can't seem to control the boy any more than she can control the fire steadily approaching her new home.

☞ And how odd this is, for isn't Sir Frederick a Christian? And yet the first encampment in which he finds himself happy—beyond even this, inspired—is a citadel of Islam. It appears to Luke that despite his stern low-church principles, Treves has fallen in love with the city's exotica, and especially the Great Bazaar where he and his wife are intoxicated by the perfumeries.

Related Characters: Luke Worley

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 101-102

Explanation and Analysis

During a surprisingly calm night as a bushfire approaches Garra Nalla, Luke finishes reading the travelogue by Sir Frederick Treves, *The Land That Is Desolate*. Throughout the travelogue, Treves has been scornfully unimpressed with every holy site he's visited on his soul-searching journey, so Luke is surprised to read that Treves loves the Islamic city of Damascus. Sir Frederick's writings have echoed Luke and Anna's experiences so far, so the passage Luke reads is a hopeful sign that positive change is still possible for them. If someone like Sir Frederick Treves can change, maybe Luke and Anna can also change and find happiness despite their recent trauma and the challenges their new home presents.

It's also notable that Treves' surprising change of heart takes place in a crowded city, where he joins a community he didn't expect to appreciate. His disappointing experiences in other sacred places largely stemmed from a disconnect between him and the people of the area, whom he considered to be gullible and pitiful. But in Damascus, Sir Frederick finds a community he can be proud of living in. Similarly, Garra Nalla's community continues to be a comforting anchor for Luke and Anna in this time of uncertainty.

☞ And the flames are burning nearer, the upper balcony close to collapse, yet she continues to rummage through the bric-à-brac. Ah, but where is the boy? She had almost forgotten him. Where could he possibly be? Is he hiding again, playing his childish games? Luke is standing in the doorway, clutching suitcases in each hand. Hurry up, he says, we have to get out of here, we have to get out of here *now*. But what about the boy, she groans, we can't go without him, we can't leave him behind—

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 104

Explanation and Analysis

As a bushfire continues to creep closer to Garra Nalla, Anna has a vivid nightmare in which she searches for the boy in a burning building. This dream is a manifestation of all of

Anna's growing anxieties combined. She's certainly wary of the bushfire and afraid of losing her new home in Garra Nalla so soon after moving in. She fears that maybe she and Luke can never find a place they can truly call home if some disaster or another will always force them somewhere else. But most of all, she's afraid of leaving the boy behind, or of the boy abandoning her.

The boy isn't a real child—just an imaginary projection of Anna's unborn son following her miscarriage. So by frantically searching for the boy in her nightmare, Anna reveals that she's unwilling to let go of the boy, despite the fact that, in reality, he's already gone. This image perfectly captures the way in which Anna has been suppressing her grief since the miscarriage. Staying and looking for the boy is dangerous, as the building is burning down. But Anna refuses to escape to safety, as she still can't accept that her boy tragically didn't survive the birth. This nightmare says it more clearly than ever: Anna can't move on with her life until she lets the boy go.

☞ 'Oh no,' he sighs, "that's the bird. That's the one I told you about, the bird in the banksia tree."
'Are you sure?' Anna stares at the stiff form on the mat. He must be mistaken. It can't be that bird. This is just a common wattledbird, one of the predators of the garden, no loss to anyone.
'Yes, that's it! That's the bird. Wouldn't I know it?'
She looks at him in exasperation, amazed to see that he is distraught.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 125

Explanation and Analysis

After miraculously making it through a firestorm that nearly destroyed Garra Nalla, Luke and Anna return to their home to find a dead bird on the floor. Anna is surprised at how upset Luke becomes as he realizes that it's a bird he's seen before. Luke's reaction to this sight makes more sense in the context of his grief over Anna's recent miscarriage. This moment echoes an earlier encounter with a dead swan that was electrocuted by wires. In both cases, a dead bird reminds Luke of the son he never had and forces his grief to the forefront of his mind.

The sight of the dead owl-like bird also revisits the theme of nature vs. civilization, as the bird likely would have been able to escape from the blaze if it hadn't gotten stuck in the Worleys' chimney. Once again, a manmade structure inadvertently causes an innocent animal to die, reminding Luke and Anna of their own son's death. As always, a dead bird also represents the possibility that positive change is impossible, or at least very difficult. If death follows the couple wherever they go, they might never find peace unless they finally face their grief.

☞ In those bleak hours after they had cleaned the sticky blood from Anna's body and wheeled her into a pale blue hospital room, the hospital counsellor asked them if they wanted to give their child a name, and they nodded, blankly, and said yes, it would be a good idea. But in the numbness of their grief, no name presented itself and thereafter they had come to think of him as 'the boy.' It seemed so much more intimate than any given name.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 131

Explanation and Analysis

While wandering the charred wasteland left in the wake of the recent firestorm, Luke mentally revisits the horrible memory of Anna's miscarriage. This flashback finally reveals the whole truth about the boy, who was always an imaginary phantom in Luke and Anna's minds. Simply calling him "the boy" seems appropriate for a child who was never really allowed to live or be a person—a boy who's often present but never really in focus. By calling him the boy, Luke and Anna almost seem to capture him in the moment just before he dies—before he has a name of his own.

Luke and Anna kept the boy in their thoughts without directly acknowledging him, but this moment is the turning point for Luke. After this, he can no longer ignore how painful it was to lose the boy. After lingering in the background for most of the novel, this traumatic event is made even more startling through its raw imagery. The event has finally been brought into the light, and it's likely nothing will be the same.

☞ He shakes his head. 'Not the fire,' he murmurs. 'Not the fire.'

'The boy?'

He nods, unable to speak, and stands on the spot, as if to take another step is entirely beyond him. She puts her arms around him, steadying herself because he is heavy, and she absorbs the shudder and heave of his body, clasping his back and drawing him into her. And they stand there, in the doorway of their home, and they hold one another for a very long time.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley (speaker), The Boy

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 133-134

Explanation and Analysis

After flashing back to Anna's miscarriage, Luke comes home to her in tears, and the two of them finally acknowledge the grief that they've hidden for so long. Anna assumes that Luke is upset by what the firestorm has done to the area, but instead he's mourning the boy they never had. This moment of open sadness and relief might have only been possible in Garra Nalla, as it was the sight of the desolation left behind by the recent firestorm that reminded Luke of that terrible day at the hospital. In the novel's conflict between nature and civilization, nature is often harsh and challenging, but its harshness is ultimately what pushed the couple to openly acknowledge the loss of their child.

Luke and Anna's long embrace is a sign that all of their emotional barriers have fallen. Now that the two of them have accepted the weight of their grief, it seems likely that they can begin to heal and move on. This marks a pivotal moment of character growth for both of them, as well as a promise of real change in their lives, however painful it might be. Their short and simple dialogue says everything there is to know about the pain they're facing, and their silence as they embrace speaks louder than any words they could have said.

☞ And yes, it is him, it's the boy, and she sees now that the sloop is for him, is waiting to carry him to his next destination. Ah, she says, so you are leaving us. So you are on your way at last. But it's okay, it's alright; yes, she thinks, I am ready for this, and she raises her arm in a soft salute. Thank you, she says. Thank you for staying with us all this time.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, The Boy

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 137-138

Explanation and Analysis

While attending a celebratory picnic with the townspeople of Garra Nalla, Anna sees the boy paddling away in a small boat across the lagoon. Because the boy is only a figment of her imagination, Anna's vision of him in this moment confirms that she's finally ready to let the boy go and move on with her life. The lingering trauma of her miscarriage manifested itself as this phantom child for a long time, but now that she's faced her grief head-on, she feels at peace with the boy leaving her for good. Her real unborn child has been gone for a long time, but it isn't until now that Anna can fully accept it.

This goodbye is the culmination of Anna's character arc and a sign that she's significantly changed and grown as a person. Almost everything she's done throughout the novel up to this point was an attempt to suppress or hide from her grief, and she was always distressed when the boy didn't show up for long stretches of time. But now, surrounded by the supportive community of Garra Nalla and pushed past her emotional limits by the recent firestorm, Anna is ready to let go of her past trauma and give life another chance.

☞ Miraculously, not all of the she-oaks in the garden burned. There is still a cluster of them in the south-east corner and she listens to the sound of the wind whistling through their canopy, that eerie siren song, and she remembers how it felt to sit in the canoe with the boy nestled against her chest while Luke paddled them across the lagoon; the long slow glide of the boat across the black water.

Related Characters: Anna Worley, Luke Worley, The Boy

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

In the novel's final moments, Anna reflects on her past, present, and potential future as she finds she isn't tired enough to go to bed. The unlikely survival of her she-oaks is a sign that nature has ultimately won the thematic conflict of nature vs. civilization. Even as the recent firestorm terrified her and nearly destroyed the town, it still somehow left some of her favorite plants alive. For as much as untamed nature creates problems for Luke and Anna in

their new home, it also brings them joy and comfort in unexpected ways. They most likely would never have made this much progress towards a happier life so quickly if they had stayed in the city.

Anna's reflections on canoeing with the boy are a reminder that Anna is still a flawed and complicated human being. Even though she's changed for the better over the course of

the novel, her feelings about the boy won't disappear overnight. There's still plenty of progress to be made, but it's clear in this moment that the most difficult part is over. And although Anna dwells on memories of the boy, she doesn't see him at this point. This implies that she really has accepted that he's left her for good. At the end of her long struggle, this gives her peace.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

A 34-year-old Australian man named Luke Worley has recently picked up the hobby of birdwatching. Even though he grew up in a suburban home with a beautiful garden, he has never been interested in **birds** prior to this point in his life. He might have thought this was funny some time ago, but things have changed in recent years. He's developed his new interest in birdwatching ever since he moved to the coast with his wife Anna. Luke and Anna used to live in the city, where the birds were much harder to notice amid the bustle and noise. On some early mornings in the city, Luke would hear a sorrowful bird call that he was always curious about, but he never quite got around to identifying it.

In the recent past, before they moved out of the city, Luke and Anna gradually begin to feel dissatisfied with their living situation. Anna has a chest infection and has been diagnosed with asthma, which disrupts her physically active lifestyle and damages her self-esteem as a result. Meanwhile, Luke begins to become disillusioned with city life, feeling less optimistic about his future and more depressed by his surroundings. In bed one night, Luke looks at a tired and sickly Anna gasping from her inhaler, and he knows that it's time for a change. He can't bear to see her like this, and the next day he suggests that they move to the country and work from home.

Anna is very open to the idea of moving to the country. Luke's parents are more skeptical, though Luke's father Ken admits that the polluted air in the city is probably what caused Anna's asthma. While Anna's friends assume that she's moving for her health, Anna secretly feels disillusioned with the city, much like her husband. In her shabby, cramped apartment with Luke, she begins to feel jealous of her wealthier friends. She knows that this envy is choking her free spirit and turning her into someone she's not, so she's determined to move to a place where she can regain her once-carefree attitude.

It's notable that the first line of the novel mentions that Luke is changing in an unexpected way. This immediately establishes one of the novel's main themes: change and growth. From the beginning, it seems like it's possible for the characters to change, but how exactly they might change remains to be seen. Birds represent the possibility of change throughout the novel, so their appearance at the outset is a sign that change will be a focal point going forward. A conflict between nature and civilization is also evident in this opening section, as alluring bird songs are drowned out by the noise and distractions of city life.



The opening sequence continues with yet another unexpected change in Luke and Anna's lives: moving out to the country. In the conflict between nature and civilization, it seems like nature might be the key to a better life. The city itself seems to be draining their will to live, and a change of environment could change their mental state for the better.



This insight into Anna's mental state goes into more detail about why city life seems to be slowly killing the couple. It also introduces the idea that positive change and growth aren't the only sort of changes that might happen to Luke and Anna. In fact, Anna is already in the process of changing, but she's changing into someone bitter and miserable—someone she doesn't want to become. If a person's environment shapes who they become, a more natural and laid-back setting could take Anna's transformation in a more helpful direction.



Luke and Anna research rural and coastal towns, compiling a list of likely candidates for places to live. When they drive off in their car to visit these places, they already feel freer. They're also encouraged by the fact that their young boy chooses to go with them on this trip. The boy is usually withdrawn and rarely appears in the apartment, but now he's staring curiously out of the car windows at the new sights. They drive through a variety of rural towns near the coast, but all of them seem either too old or too new for Luke or Anna's tastes. One afternoon, a wrong turn takes them into a small coastal town called Garra Nalla.

By all appearances, Garra Nalla seems like the perfect place for Luke and Anna to live. The town is small, quiet, and has many beautiful natural features, including sandhills, white-sand beaches, and a lagoon where black **swans** swim. Anna thinks the town is "almost too picturesque" as she looks at the variety of colorful flowers and trees. Even the boy is excited by what he sees. As Luke and Anna stand on the headland and watch the sea, they wonder how a beautiful place like Garra Nalla hasn't been turned into a crowded resort yet. On their way home, a local in a nearby town explains to them that tourists avoid Garra Nalla's beach because of its dangerous riptide, which has caused four people to drown in the past five years. For Luke and Anna, this lack of tourism makes the town even more perfect.

Luke and Anna's friends can hardly believe they'd want to live in a place without shops, hotels, and the like. But this lack of activity is exactly why the couple are so in love with Garra Nalla. It feels timeless and untamed—a place where they can live simply and free of modern complications that threaten to change who they are. They also love the old-fashioned house they've chosen, which has a wrap-around veranda, a cast-iron stove in the kitchen, and a generally homey atmosphere. It's also made much more affordable by the fact that it isn't by the coast, though it's nonetheless within walking distance of the beach. While Anna sometimes hesitates to change their lives so completely, Luke remains confident in their choice. In January, they pack their things and officially move to their new home in Garra Nalla.

The fact that Luke and Anna already feel better when they leave the city is a sign that their intuitions were correct; they'll most likely be happier in a rural area. This road trip has a light, hopeful energy to it, which seems to imply that this sudden change of pace in the couple's lives is a good idea. The boy also contributes to this uplifting attitude, but the description of his behavior is nonetheless a bit odd. He apparently only shows up when he feels like it, and the couple seem almost surprised to see him in the car with them.



Here, it becomes clear that Luke and Anna are looking for a place that's as different from the city as possible. As civilization itself seems to be overcomplicating their lives, they can't help but feel drawn to the simplicity of nature, however harsh it might be. In Garra Nalla, untamed nature is so aggressively present that it has driven tourists away. This makes it "perfect" for the couple despite being dangerous, as the challenges presented by nature seem preferable to the exhausting crowds of the city. Symbolically, the presence of swans indicates that Garra Nalla could be a place where positive change is possible.



Once again, Luke and Anna reinforce their rationale for suddenly packing up and moving to the country. They realize that their surroundings are rapidly changing who they are, and so they wish to become something other than what the city is turning them into. By moving to such a wild place with so few modern conveniences, the couple is truly putting this mindset to the test. Rather than slowly changing their lifestyle as they go along, they're diving headfirst into the wildest place they can find. Being close to nature will change them, but they can't yet be sure how.



When they arrive at the house, Luke and Anna feel an excited sense of ownership, despite how musty their new home seems. The boy runs eagerly ahead of them as they unpack, exploring every room restlessly. They sleep on a mattress on the floor on their first night in the house, and Anna smiles at the evil-sounding hisses of possums on the roof. These noises frighten the boy, however. Anna calls him to the mattress and comforts him, kissing his blond curls and lulling him to sleep in her arms. Luke and Anna begin a new routine in the mornings, sitting out on the wide veranda together. Anna looks around for the boy, but strangely, she seems not to expect him to be there every morning.

Anna and Luke settle comfortably into their new lifestyle. Luke takes up birdwatching, and both he and Anna are excited to learn about the local **bird** species. They feel as though the house has always belonged to them and that they've only just now claimed what's rightfully theirs. Both of them work from home; Luke has his office up in the house's glassed-in attic, while Anna takes her laptop into the sunroom in the back. The views of the sea and the hills are incredible, making the couple feel more grounded and connected to nature than they felt in the city. They spend much of their time on the veranda. The boy often runs along the veranda dragging a stick behind him, clattering across the wooden boards.

The couple starts a garden in March, and they enjoy the unfamiliar rhythms and movements of tiring manual labor. The boy often plays in the yard as they work, dancing around and throwing things and singing off-key. Luke and Anna don't look into each other's eyes at these moments, as they'd feel too overjoyed at what their lives have become. However, this new existence isn't perfect, as Garra Nalla is in a dry area of frequent drought. The area has been experiencing a drought for the past seven years; a fact that almost makes it seem like the land is cursed. There's rain and mist in the distant hills, but the town's dryness forces Luke and Anna to conserve water as best they can.

Luke and Anna have two neighbors in Garra Nalla: Gilbert Reilly and Rodney Banfield. Gilbert (whom they call Gil) is an old widower who introduced himself shortly after the couple moved in. He often visits their house to dispense advice and local folklore. He generally likes Luke and Anna, remarking that they bring interesting new life to the town. Likewise, the couple appreciates his friendly nature and are grateful that he's not one of those old men who rants about the "good old days." Meanwhile, Rodney is a short man in his twenties and a plumber. He's secretly sleeping with a local miner's wife, and he's rumored to have a marijuana plantation in the hills.

Luke and Anna's first night in their new house is defined by the presence of untamed nature. The possums on the roof and the rustic feel of the house immediately put them into a new world, far removed from the one they're used to. Based on their initial reaction to this new, more nature-focused lifestyle, it seems promising. Once again, the boy's role in the couple's life seems very unusual. The fact that Anna doesn't expect to see him every morning is a sign that maybe he isn't a normal boy, as most mothers would be very careful to keep track of their children in a new house.



Luke's new interest in birdwatching reinforces the possibility that he and Anna are truly beginning to change in their new home. For now, their suspicions about country life seem to be correct, and nature appears to be easily winning out over civilization (in their view). Birds become a constant presence in the couple's lives from this point on, as living in Garra Nalla surrounded by wildlife begins to shape who they might become.



At this point, the unique challenges of living in nature become clear. Luke and Anna didn't expect their new lives to be perfect, but the dryness of the area will still take some getting used to. Regardless, the two of them still seem to prefer the physical challenges of nature to the emotional drain of densely packed civilization. Even with nature refusing to accommodate them, they still feel freer. Meanwhile, the moment Luke and Anna avoid making eye contact has an interesting layer of subtext. With the boy being as strange as he is, it's possible that the couple chose not to look at each other for a reason other than being too happy. They might be thinking of something neither of them wants to mention at this point.



Befriending their neighbors helps Luke and Anna begin to feel like a part of Garra Nalla's small community. Despite the fact that the couple moved to the country partly to escape the crowds, they're still compelled to meet the people of this small town. These new connections seem to make Luke and Anna feel more grounded in their new environment, possibly because they're focusing on one or two people rather than juggling too many social engagements. The town's community might become one of the key factors in the couple's new life.



Luke enjoys seeing the wide and colorful variety of **birds** on his frequent walks. One evening, around dusk, he spots an unusual, owl-like bird staring at him from a low branch. The birds in the garden usually fly away when someone approaches, but this bird continues to calmly stare at Luke while he stares back. After a few silent moments of this, Luke continues his walk home, feeling strangely elated and “pointlessly, mindlessly happy.” He’s unable to discover the species of the bird in his book that night, but he tells Anna that simply seeing the bird is more important than naming it. It’s like the boy in that way—they’ve never named him, and that’s the way it should be. Luke wishes the boy could have been there to see the bird with him, but he knows the boy is out of his control.

The encounter with the owl-like bird is one of the defining moments of Luke’s time in Garra Nalla. He seems to feel a deeper connection to nature than ever before as he stares at the strange bird, but there’s also something else on his mind, lingering just beneath the surface. It may have something to do with the boy, who once again seems to occupy a strange place in Luke and Anna’s lives. Parents can never completely control the behavior of their children, but for some reason, this seems especially true for the boy. As always, the presence of a bird indicates that more changes are on the horizon, for good or ill.



After visiting an old mansion in the area, Luke and Anna ask Gil about the history of the place. Gil explains that the mansion once belonged to the McKinnon family, who were involved in the local community back in their day. After the patriarch of the family died, the eldest son inherited the mansion, but he was soon caught in a riptide and drowned. After that, the mansion was purchased by a consortium of businessmen, who have no interest in Garra Nalla’s locals and only use the mansion for the occasional party, where they invite people from the city. Gil speaks of these businessmen scornfully, holding the McKinnons in much higher regard.

Gil’s explanation highlights the novel’s ongoing conflict between nature and civilization. Nature scares people away from Garra Nalla with its deadly riptides, but civilization still occasionally tries to invade the area as the consortium purchases property nearby. With his knowledge of the area and strong opinions about the local history, it’s clear that Gil is a loyal member of the town’s community. He seems to care far more for Garra Nalla’s wellbeing than for anything outside its borders.



Gil also recounts the story of how Garra Nalla’s coastal area was once called Ross’s Farm. An old soldier named Ross unsuccessfully tried to start a farm on the coast after World War I, but he eventually shot himself. As Gil explains the history of the area, he tells another story about the time he heard gunshots coming from the edge of the lagoon. He found people from the business consortium shooting swans. Though they told Gil they had a permit, Gil called the police to put a stop to their reckless behavior, as the shooting was dangerous for anyone in the sandhills. He remarks that his mother used to bake swans occasionally, and that they tend to be delicious.

As Gil continues to tell Luke and Anna the history of the area, nature and civilization are once again at odds with each other. Gil’s concern for the town’s community certainly extends to the wildlife, as his concern for the swans demonstrates. However, his admission that swans are delicious is a sign that his reverence for nature has its limits. Otherwise, he might believe that eating the occasional swan is just another way of nature taking its course. In this moment, as in many others, Gil’s role as a character is to connect Luke and Anna to the larger community they’re gradually becoming a part of.



In April, Anna buys an old yellow canoe from a neighboring town. After a local surfer teaches them the basics, Anna and Luke make it a habit to paddle along the lagoon in the late afternoons. Sometimes the boy comes with them, sitting contentedly in the canoe and nervously freezing whenever a swan comes near. During these days, Luke begins to have recurring dreams about massive tidal waves that swallow Garra Nalla and submerge it underwater. But rather than being frightening, these strange dreams comfort Luke. As he swims in the sunlit waters of his dream, the boy swims alongside him. The boy’s face is glowing, and translucent fish swim beautifully around his unravelling blond curls.

Luke and Anna’s new canoeing hobby indicates that moving to Garra Nalla was probably a good idea. They’re enjoying themselves and connecting with nature much more than they ever did in the city, and a happier life seems to be within reach. But Luke’s dreams tell a different story, as they feel vaguely ominous despite seeming to make Luke happy. The tidal wave is a reminder that the natural beauty of Garra Nalla could become violent at any moment. And the boy appears as an almost angelic figure in the dream, which once again implies that he may not be what he seems.



At night, Luke tends to read, as he doesn't want to keep looking at a screen after working all day. Anna, on the other hand, tends to watch the news in the evenings. This habit started when she was a teenager. Her late father would watch the news constantly after coming home from long shifts, so Anna had to watch the news with him in order to spend time with him. This had made her feel more like an adult, and more included in his world. Now, however, she watches the nightly news to keep in touch with the world outside of Garra Nalla. She also keeps up with friends and posts humorous anecdotes about country life on social media, while Luke mostly stays offline.

Shortly after the couple moved into their new home, Luke found two old trunks in a shed behind the house. The trunks were full of antique books that had once belonged to a reverend who retired in Garra Nalla. But rather than religious texts, the reverend's books were mostly old travelogues, documenting journeys and explorations around the world. Now, Luke has been poring through these interesting old tomes and begins reading one called *The Land That Is Desolate*, written by a physician named Sir Frederick Treves. The book, published in 1913, gives an account of Sir Frederick's travels in Palestine. Luke had forgotten about the book until he saw Anna watching footage of a rocket strike in Gaza on the news and became more interested in Palestine's history.

Upon reading *The Land That Is Desolate*, Luke is surprised to discover that Sir Frederick Treves seems to be a cold and cynical man of science, rather than the faithful pilgrim Luke had imagined. After the death of his daughter, Treves traveled to the Holy Land to find a sense of meaning, but all he seemed to find was disappointment. Luke reads Sir Frederick's scathing account of The Promised Land, which describes it as a hollow and decaying place that long ago lost whatever beauty it might have had. Treves goes on to describe many holy sites as miserable and unremarkable locations.

Even as Luke and Anna adjust to life in Garra Nalla and change their routines, some things seem to stay the same. Anna continues her long-held habit of watching the nightly news, in contrast to her many recent lifestyle changes. This implies that maybe some things will never change, despite how the couple's circumstances have shifted drastically. Anna's habits of watching the news and keeping up with social media indicate that she still feels a connection to the broader community she left behind since moving to Garra Nalla. But lasting change takes time, and Anna isn't obligated to ignore her old community just because she's joined a new one.



It's possible that Luke becomes interested in the book by Treves partly because he's interested in how a place (in this case, the Middle East) can experience such drastic changes in such a relatively short amount of time. Notably, Sir Frederick Treves is a real historical figure who wrote the travelogue described in this passage.



The description of Sir Frederick Treves mourning his daughter is the first direct mention of grief in the novel. This theme will become more significant later, and its presence here hints at the kinds of challenges Luke and Anna might face. Treves' journey already seems to echo the couple's experience in some ways, as they both venture away from their homes to escape from a painful way of life and search for a new purpose. While Luke and Anna aren't quite as disappointed with Garra Nalla as Treves is with the Holy Land, their new home still presents comparable problems of drought that can make it feel like a wasteland at times.



A passage about olives in the book reminds Luke of the new olive plantation on the coast. He reflects on how fresh changes are coming to Garra Nalla, and how his and Anna's arrival is just one of those changes. He puts the book down and watches the stars as he stands alone with his thoughts, knowing that even the stars' fixed position in the sky is only an illusion. Things are always moving and changing. On a moonlit night recently, Luke took Anna out to the headland, where they embraced beneath a she-oak thicket, with the sound of the sea churning below them.

This moment of reflection highlights the novel's themes of change and nature. After living in Garra Nalla for some time, Luke has begun to feel more connected with the natural world, which gives him a sense of how everything—including him—is interconnected. Not only are the couple's lives changing since they moved, but they also change Garra Nalla simply by living there. Luke realizes that for everything, even nature itself, change is constant and inevitable. He isn't yet sure how living close to nature will ultimately change him and Anna (or vice versa), but he knows more transformations are on their way.



CHAPTER 2

While Luke and Anna are still enjoying their new home, the complete lack of rain in Garra Nalla continues to be an annoyance. They had known that the area was prone to drought before they moved there, but they realize that hearing about the dryness isn't the same as living in it. The couple is amazed at how dry the air is, especially when compared to the damp smell of their apartment back in the city. This dryness gradually settles into them, and they begin to feel as if it's a part of them now. When their water tank starts to smell a bit off, Luke installs a filtration system beneath their sink. His skill in this practical matter surprises Anna, who assumed Luke wouldn't be able to handle some of the house's tougher projects.

Luke and Anna's struggles with the drought serve as a reminder that nature will always push back against their attempts to settle in Garra Nalla. In the context of Sir Frederick Treves' disappointment with the dry and desolate Holy Land, the merits of living in a drought country are called into question. By settling in Garra Nalla, Luke and Anna are attempting to bring their own little piece of civilization into a wild, natural space. This isn't impossible so far, but it does present its own unique challenges.



As they walk by the lagoon one afternoon, Luke and Anna meet Alan Watts, another resident of Garra Nalla who lives nearby. Alan, his wife Bette, and their two children Zack and Briony live in a large but sparsely decorated house on the headland. Luke and Anna quickly become friends with the Watts family, and they begin playing tennis together on weekends. The tennis court is near an army base, so helicopters sometimes pass overhead as the couples compete. One day, a helicopter lands and two young soldiers step out. As Luke and Alan chat with them, Luke can't help but feel old compared to the soldiers, even though they're not much younger than him. He feels as though he's lost much of his nerve and youthful energy.

Once again, the tight-knit community of Garra Nalla proves to be a grounding and comforting element of Luke and Anna's new lives. Befriending the Watts makes the Worleys feel even more welcome in the small town, helping them tolerate the difficult climate. Luke's insecurity about his age reveals another change that has taken place—one that Luke hardly noticed until now. This realization is contrasted with the youthful energy of Luke's tennis matches with Anna and the Watts. The contrast highlights how aging can change someone over time in surprising and upsetting ways, but also maintains the hope that not all of Luke's youth is gone.



That same evening, Luke, Anna, and the Watts play cards and discuss how they've been dealing with the drought. As the men examine brochures for a portable desalination plant, Anna and Bette stand by the window and watch a distant pod of dolphins. To Anna's surprise, Bette suddenly asks her if she's thought about starting a family. Anna answers that they haven't decided yet, as she and Luke "have to decide where home is" first. Anna knows that she isn't giving Bette the whole story, and Anna hopes that the boy isn't around to hear this conversation.

Luke's father Ken visits Garra Nalla in July, seeming restless as he gets accustomed to his new retirement. Ken seems clearly unimpressed with the rural area his son has moved to, wondering why Luke would want to live in a place without any of the usual features of a modern city. Luke holds his tongue. He doesn't feel like arguing with his father about the move or his law degree, which Ken believes has been squandered by Luke's career choices. During a walk one evening, Ken asks Luke how Anna has been handling her asthma, as well as "that other business." Luke is silently annoyed that Ken can't even openly talk about this recent, tragic event—seemingly something about losing a child. But it also occurs to Luke that this "other business" probably hurt Ken, who has no grandchildren.

Luke and Anna continue to tolerate the presence of Ken, who tries unsuccessfully not to seem bored. Anna privately jokes about Ken, comparing him to an old-fashioned school inspector, but Luke is miffed by the way Ken condescends to Gil. In the meantime, Anna notices that the boy never seems to appear when Ken or Gil are around. She wonders if the boy doesn't like being around old men. On Ken's last day in Garra Nalla, Anna hears the boy crying in the middle of the night and gets out of bed to check on him. His bed is empty, but this doesn't scare Anna, as she knows the boy always comes back.

Spring arrives in Garra Nalla, bringing a relentless wind with it. A dry, scouring wind blows constantly, surprising even Gil with its consistent intensity. While Anna tries to put up with it, the wind eventually begins to get on her nerves as it continues for weeks. The sound of the wind rattling against the old house keeps her up at night, and Luke's wry detachment annoys her. He's a much heavier sleeper, so the wind doesn't bother him nearly as much. One day, Anna leaves the laundry out to dry on the line outdoors, and a sheet blows off the line and into a patch of bracken. When she reaches down to pick it up, she finds a copperhead snake coiled underneath. Frightened, she has Luke ask Gil to get rid of it. After dispatching the snake, Gil winks and remarks that now Anna can really call herself a local.

This sudden question once again highlights how Garra Nalla's community might help to make Luke and Anna's lives better, albeit indirectly. Anna is clearly hiding something here, maybe even from herself. But with Bette as her friend, Anna can't keep it hidden forever. The community's concern for her forces her to think about something she has been avoiding: something concerning the boy. Anna's answer to Bette's question is a major clue about the boy. Either Anna is hiding him, or maybe Bette can't even perceive him.



Ken's negative attitude about Garra Nalla brings the conflict between nature and civilization back into focus. There's a deeper disconnect between Luke and Ken, as Ken can't imagine why Luke would want to live without modern conveniences, not understanding what Luke wants from a closeness with nature. Another disconnect stems from Ken's unwillingness to mention the traumatic event that affected Anna. But ironically, even though Luke resents Ken for refusing to name the event, Luke has been just as quiet about it throughout the novel. This exchange offers a major clue about the true nature of the boy.



When Luke resents Ken for talking down to Gil, he reveals that he's already become defensive about the community of Garra Nalla. By taking Gil's side against his own father, Luke shows how much he appreciates the town's community and proudly considers himself a part of it. Anna's reaction to the boy's disappearance essentially confirms that the boy is most likely more of an apparition than a real, literal child. The implications of this will develop over the course of the novel, but in every case, Anna still cares deeply for the boy regardless of what he is—or isn't.



Luke and Anna once again grapple with the consequences of suddenly transitioning from civilization to nature. At this point, Anna begins to become the focal character of the novel a bit more than Luke, as the challenges of living in Garra Nalla affect her more strongly. Dealing with the harsher elements of nature makes her seriously question whether country life is right for her after all. Despite Anna's misgivings, Gil's slightly teasing remark reminds her that problems such as wind, droughts, and snakes are all part of living in the community of Garra Nalla. While Anna's struggles discourage her, they only make her more of a true citizen of Garra Nalla in Gil's opinion.



The constant wind doesn't abate as September and October roll around, and the drought is equally stubborn. While Luke and Anna hope for rain every time they hear a rumble of distant thunder, they eventually give up hope that the drought will end any time soon. It's easy enough for Luke to tune out the wind as he works with his headphones on, but the wind still bothers Anna as her mental health deteriorates. Back in the city, the weather had just been background noise, but out in the country, the weather defines her world much more strongly. She begins to wonder if moving to Garra Nalla was a mistake, but Luke reassures her. He insists that they give it a proper chance by staying in Garra Nalla for at least another year. He's patient with her, but he doesn't want to think about leaving yet.

After getting through a long and busy period of work, Luke continues reading the travelogue by Sir Frederick Treves. Frederick is once again unimpressed by his visits to holy sites. He looks down contemptuously on the pilgrims visiting the supposed site of Cavalry, describing them as gullible fools and painting the entire experience in a depressing light. As Luke reads this, he can't help but compare Treves's commentary to Ken's skeptical and cynical attitude. He reflects on Sir Frederick's disillusionment; can such a dry and desolate place really be the Promised Land? Meanwhile, Anna watches the nightly news while the boy plays on the rug in front of her. As she watches the violent horrors of the Iraq war on the screen, she tells the boy that at least he'll never have to be a soldier.

On a Saturday afternoon, Luke and Alan discuss the book by Sir Frederick Treves as they clear weeds from behind the sandhills. Luke marvels at how the Middle East has become an area of constant war, when it was apparently so uneventful during Sir Frederick's day. Alan surprises Luke by telling him that Gil has a grandson deployed as a commando in Afghanistan. Luke wonders why Gil wouldn't have told him, and Alan explains that Gil is superstitious. Gil believes that if he doesn't dwell on it, his boy will be safe. This conversation reminds Luke of the boy—his own boy—and he realizes he hasn't thought about the boy in a while. On the way home, Luke sees a boy who looks a lot like his boy, and Alan points out a dead **swan** nearby that was apparently electrocuted by wires overhead.

The challenges presented by a lifestyle closer to nature continue to become more intense. Luke's insistence that the two of them stay in Garra Nalla stems from two different factors. The first is that the area's oppressive weather doesn't bother him as much as it bothers Anna. But another factor is that Luke has already become attached to Garra Nalla and is determined to give his idea a fair chance. In Luke's opinion, the downsides of living in the "wild" country are outweighed by the benefits. But Anna also has a point, as improving her mental health was one of the main reasons she agreed to move out of the city in the first place.



Once again, Sir Frederick's travelogue mirrors the experiences of Luke and Anna. Treves was hoping to find comfort and meaning in the Promised Land, but instead he finds a miserable place he considers to be a wasteland. Likewise, Luke and Anna fled to Garra Nalla to create a new life for themselves, but they have since been plagued by drought and constant wind. In both cases, nature's harshness (compared to the comfort of civilization) makes it more difficult to meaningfully connect with it. Meanwhile, Anna's comment about the boy heavily implies that he'll never grow up or is unreal in some way. She seems to be comforting herself rather than the boy in this moment, possibly showing a glimpse of an internal struggle she hasn't made explicit yet.



Gil's secret is just as surprising to the reader as it is to Luke in this moment. After he's been so open and honest throughout the novel, it seems odd that Gil would keep something so significant to himself. But this reveals that no character—not even Gil—is immune to grief or the fear of loss. Luke's internal reaction to this news is yet another hint about the boy. The appearance of a dead swan nearby reinforces this sudden focus on death and tragedy, and the sight of the bird most likely reminds Luke of trauma or anxiety of his own. The electrocuted swan also represents another violent clash between nature and civilization, as well as the possibility that positive change might be unlikely for Luke and Anna if death follows them wherever they go.



The drought and the winds persist into November. Still shaken by the rough climate, Anna wonders if more snakes will start showing up, and also wonders what it would take for them to move back to the city. As Luke watches **birds** on the veranda one evening, she tries to float the idea off-handedly, remarking that she doesn't think she could live in Garra Nalla all her life. Luke continues watching the birds, and Anna eventually goes inside, frustrated. But Luke has been paying attention the entire time, and he knows she's upset. Understanding that Anna needs a break from the country, he suggests that they take a vacation into town. With feigned reluctance, Anna agrees.

When the couple tells Gil that they're visiting the city, he tells them to be careful not to "get caught there." Feeling that Garra Nalla is truly their home now, Luke tells Gil not to worry about it. While Luke feels optimistic about the vacation on the drive out of Garra Nalla, he almost immediately sinks into a bad mood when they've arrived in town. He complains about the noise and the crowded beaches, and he even misses the gulls back home: the ones that live on a diet of shellfish rather than chips and other discarded human food. After five days in the city, Luke heads home early, while Anna resolves to stay in town for a while longer.

During her time alone in the city, Anna is happy to finally be out of the wind and free from Luke's complaints. But eventually, she begins to feel confined and homesick, missing the spacious rooms of her house and the natural beauty of Garra Nalla. She realizes that Luke has created a situation where she can't truly feel at home anywhere, whether urban or rural. Anna also notices that the boy hasn't appeared to her during her entire stay in the city. She wonders why the boy always takes his father's side, and she realizes that she hasn't even seen the boy in three weeks. When she tries to picture his face, it's pale and hazy like an old photograph.

At this point, Anna's recent doubts and anxieties reach their tipping point, fortunately without an argument. Just like she did back in the city, Anna feels that her environment is turning her into something she doesn't want to be. This time, however, she's discouraged by the challenges that nature throws at her every day in Garra Nalla. While she does most likely need a respite from the constant wind, she already knows that the city has problems of its own. Regardless, her determination to take a vacation pays off, and she seems more likely to see things clearly once she's out of the wind. But even as Luke agrees to take a break, the symbol of the birds is still present, implying that Garra Nalla remains a place where positive change can happen.



The couple's reactions when returning to the city reveals that Luke has changed much more than Anna has so far. Luke's discomfort with the urban area and its birds reveals that he's already made himself at home in Garra Nalla despite only having lived there for a few months. But that brief stretch of country life was enough to make him miss Garra Nalla almost as soon as he left. Nature is preferable to civilization as far as Luke is concerned, but Anna is still willing to give the latter another try.



Anna's crisis is caused in part by the fact that she feels stuck between two worlds: nature and civilization. It's possible that she was searching for some kind of perfect middle ground by returning to the city, but it's clear that a "perfect" place for her doesn't really exist. Instead, she's forced to decide which place she's more willing to call home: the comfortable but claustrophobic city, or the beautiful but brutal country. Her anxieties about the boy seem to be calling her back to Garra Nalla, and the way she thinks about him confirms that he simply appears and disappears like a phantom or hallucination. The imagery of this moment implies that there's something about him that she's still unwilling to face directly.



Before she leaves the city, Anna resolves to live in Garra Nalla for at least one more year. However, she also privately decides that one day, they must move again. Until then, she wants a project to work on—something meaningful to leave behind before they move away. She researches the kinds of plants she could grow in a garden and decides to plant some weeping she-oaks. She considers this particular kind of tree to be beautiful and mysterious like no other plant she knows. To her annoyance, Gil advises her not to plant she-oaks, as they're extremely flammable. On her first night back home, she digs for more information on the internet and discovers that her she-oaks are fireweeds that "respond to fire as others do to rain," making them sound almost phoenix-like.

Gil visits Luke and Anna in an uproar one night to tell them that the consortium is planning to create a massive tree plantation in Garra Nalla. He furiously explains that the reckless landscaping, chemicals, and pesticides involved in the process will poison the lagoon and pollute the area, forcing the swans to breed elsewhere. Anna is outraged at this news, wondering if the local government will do anything about it. Gil explains that the council has always been in the pockets of the developers. Both Anna and Luke are upset by the idea that their quiet country town will be disrupted by noise and pollution, but Luke soon begins to calm down about it, which annoys Anna. She tells the boy that Luke doesn't "deal with things," and the boy runs off, seeming to take his father's side as usual.

Anna is usually charmed and reassured by Luke's personality and sharp mind, but during the next few weeks, she starts to resent him. She doubts that he's created a good life for them, and she feels as though his old personality is slipping away. Where he was once sharp and alert, he now seems distant and stupidly content, almost as if he's high or drunk. Anna watches him have an inane conversation about **birds** with Rodney on the veranda one day, and she despises the dull, boyish look on Luke's face as he grins.

Anna looks out the window at Luke coming home from birdwatching one afternoon, and she suddenly feels completely alienated from him. She feels a dizzying sense of vertigo and panic while she watches her own husband as if he's just a feature of the landscape, or a stranger. In this frightening moment, Anna has the sensation that everything in her life is illusory, inconsequential, or slipping away from her.

By deciding to plant the she-oaks, Anna finally commits to living in the country and leaning into nature, on the condition that she knows it isn't permanent. This new fascination with a specific type of plant is what finally convinces her to leave civilization behind again. The phoenix-like nature of the she-oaks will become more significant later on. It implies that a violent or dramatic rebirth might need to take place before Anna can fully grow into herself as a person.



Gil's concerns about the local environment and his distrust of the consortium once again show his dedication to the community of Garra Nalla. However, one of the reasons why Luke and Anna enjoy Gil's company is that he isn't just a bitter old man who hates outsiders. Gil eagerly welcomed Luke and Anna into Garra Nalla's community almost as soon as they moved in, but the consortium's tree plantation is a disruption he can't approve of. This is because he knows that this development will hurt the people of the town as well as the wildlife. Once again, civilization tries to invade nature, and their conflict threatens to ruin the couple's new home.



At this stage, the possibility of change becomes frightening and frustrating for Anna, rather than hopeful. Garra Nalla seems to be changing Luke, but not in the way she expected. Luke is drifting through a daydream from Anna's point of view, while Anna still struggles to feel at home in this place, especially with her husband acting so odd. The presence of birds indicates that a change is taking place, but for once it seems to be a negative one.



All of the frustrations and anxieties that have been affecting Anna recently come to a disorienting climax. Anna has allowed her discomfort with change to grow into an existential crisis, as she loses her grip on Luke and even on herself. The novel is named after this defining moment in Anna's development, as she struggles to accept the idea that people (including herself) can suddenly change in ways she isn't comfortable with.



The thought occurs to Anna that she and Luke could disappear and nothing would change. Is there no meaning to their lives beyond their daily struggle to survive? Anna almost wants to grab onto Luke and steady herself when he walks inside. She feels lost and unmoored, and she wonders if this is because the boy seems to have abandoned them. For some reason or another, she senses that an important part of her is fading and dying.

In the midst of her sudden crisis, Anna is struck by how insignificant her life feels when compared to the vast natural space around her small home. The noise and bustle of the city might have distracted her mind and numbed her existential pain, but out in the country, there's almost nothing separating Anna from her thoughts. She feels that even if she manages to change for the better, her life might not matter in the grand scheme of things. Her feeling of being lost and directionless stems from this realization, but it's also fueled by her fears about the boy abandoning her. It seems that Anna needs to untangle her unspoken feelings about this strange boy before she can ever find peace.



CHAPTER 3

In late November, Anna and Luke visit a nearby tree nursery to buy she-oaks for the garden. Afterwards, Alan and Bette suggest that the four of them have lunch at the Wolga hotel. The weather is nice as they eat on the hotel's veranda, and Anna feels like she might be alright after all. Back home, she plants the she-oaks in the garden, arranging them in a disorganized way so that they look wilder. Luke, Anna, Gil, and the Watts celebrate the new garden at Luke and Anna's house, taking the lack of wind as a good omen. After their visitors have left, Luke and Anna make love in the living room. Then they sit out on the veranda and drift into a contented sleep.

Despite her recent crisis, everything finally seems to be improving for Anna. Her community of friends helps her escape from her worries (at least temporarily) and begin to develop into the kind of person she wants to be. The garden might represent Anna's mental state at this point, as she fills it with beautiful new plants in the hopes that they'll grow strong and healthy. For a moment, it seems like Anna's life might finally be changing for the better, partly thanks to her new community connections in Garra Nalla. But the mention of the lack of wind being a good omen will soon become ironic as a new potential crisis arises.



When Anna wakes up that afternoon, she's surprised to see that the blue sky has been stained by a smudge of brown. She sees a cloud of smoke rising from behind the distant hills, and Luke remarks that it looks like a bushfire. Anna expresses concern, but Luke reassures her, saying that it's far away at the moment. Alan approaches the house to retrieve his wife's forgotten sunglasses, and he also brings up the distant bushfire. Still concerned, Anna says she's glad they live near the water. Alan insists that there have been fires in this area before, but they never reach the coast.

News of the bushfire feels ominous from the start, as the natural beauty of the area threatens to erupt into flames. Just when everything seemed perfect, nature continues to test Luke and Anna's willingness to stay in Garra Nalla, rather than returning to the relative safety of civilization. The first sight of smoke has a menacing aura to it despite Alan's calm attitude. It seems likely that the distant bushfire heralds the arrival of a significant change, whether for good or ill.



The next morning, Luke and Anna awake to find that the air around their house is full of smoke, obscuring the landscape outside. It's clear that the fire is still quite far away from them, but the smoke clouds make the house stifling hot all day. That night, they find themselves almost hypnotized by the sight of the distant mountain range burning. Though they know the fire isn't near and they're probably being paranoid, they still have trouble sleeping in the sweltering heat. Anna wakes up at around three in the morning and cries to herself, thinking of the boy as Luke sleeps. She hasn't seen the boy at all in weeks, and she wonders if they did something to offend him, and whether he might have abandoned them. She makes tea and feels comforted by the coziness of the kitchen, then she goes back to bed.

Luke wakes up Anna later in the morning and tells her that the bushfire has reached the foothills. Now that the fire is closer, they're forced to take precautions throughout the house, such as filling buckets and the bathtub with water and having towels on hand. Later that day, the fire damages the power station in the hills, and Garra Nalla loses electricity. As the smoke in the air gets thicker, Luke says he's going to go check on Gil, insisting that Anna should stay home and keep out of the smoke to avoid an asthma attack. Anna goes with Luke anyway, and Gil mentions that he's never seen a fire like this before. Nonetheless, he maintains that fires never reach the coast.

Luke reads by candlelight back in his home that night, wanting to know the ending of his old book by Sir Frederick Treves. To Luke's surprise, Sir Frederick finally arrives in a place that isn't disappointing at the end of his journey. Treves describes the ancient city of Damascus as a beautiful and sweet-smelling place, full of romantic and inspiring sights. Luke reflects on how surprising it is that Treves has fallen in love with the Islamic city of Damascus of all places, despite being a Christian. Meanwhile, Anna works on her laptop and writes a message to her sister in Hong Kong. Despite the fire, Anna doesn't wish she was somewhere else. She reflects on the strange sense of calm in the house, especially on a night like this, which should make her tense.

The surprising abundance of smoke builds tension and confirms that the bushfire might become a serious problem, even as others insist that fires never reach the coast. After enduring constant wind and drought, the wild area around Garra Nalla gives Luke and Anna their most dangerous challenge yet. If the fire gets too close, their willingness to live away from civilization might be pushed to its limits. At the same time, Anna still struggles to process her feelings about the boy as her stress builds. Even though the bushfire is just a random natural event, she can't help but feel guilty, as if she deserves to be abandoned by the boy and by nature itself. Why she might feel this way will become clearer later on.



Nature continues to encroach on Garra Nalla's tiny spot of civilization, interrupting the citizens' lives and threatening to do much worse. The neighbors' assurances start to sound less and less credible as the fire grows closer by the minute. The possibility of the bushfire reaching the coast likely worsens Anna's fears that she and Luke made the wrong choice by moving out of the city. But Gil remains a steadfast friend, functioning as a reassuring presence to keep the community of Garra Nalla together in this stressful time.



One last time, Sir Frederick's journey mirrors that of Luke and Anna, at least potentially. After struggling through a long series of desolate and depressing locations, Treves finally finds a place that makes him content. In the same vein, Luke and Anna's current troubles might soon pay off as they find a metaphorical Promised Land of their own. Treves's trip to Damascus also highlights every person's capacity to change in surprising ways. If a devout Christian like Sir Frederick can love an Islamic city, Luke and Anna might truly change and make their home in Garra Nalla despite their doubts and inexperience.



Later in the night, Anna's feeling of calm fades and is replaced by a growing fear of losing the house. She imagines what would happen if the bushfire does reach the coast, and wonders if they'll ever have a home that won't be constantly threatened. In a fitful sleep, she dreams that she's in a burning department store full of possessions she didn't know she owned. In the dream, Luke tells her that they need to hurry out of there, but she keeps rummaging through the items in the store, desperately looking for the boy, whom she doesn't want to leave behind.

Anna's nightmare reveals the intensity of her fears at this point and provides more clues about the boy. While the fire in her dream corresponds to the bushfire she fears in the real world, it might also represent her own internal world crashing down around her as she begins to feel lost. In the dream, Luke insists that the two of them escape the burning building—in other words, move on. But Anna seems unwilling to leave this dangerous situation, and the only reason is the boy. In this light, it's possible that the boy is something she needs to let go of—something she's already lost but refuses to forget.



Anna wakes from this dream with her heart pounding, but she's relieved to hear that the wind has dropped. Over breakfast, Luke tells her that the authorities have issued an alert for every town along the coast, including Garra Nalla. He explains that the wind is due to pick back up again in the afternoon. On their battery radio, they hear that the Wolga hotel—where they dined just a few days ago—has burned to the ground. Later that morning, Alan calls and tells them that Bette can't decide whether or not to take the kids away from town until the fires have died down. Alan insists that it's not safe to drive while there are fires raging, and he suggests that the two couples play tennis. Anna is bemused by the idea, but Luke figures playing a game is better than waiting around in dread.

The bushfire reaching the coast becomes a serious possibility at this point, and the townspeople don't even try to dismiss the idea anymore. But Garra Nalla's community still comes together at this uneasy time, helping each other relax as they wait for things to resolve. Luke and Anna's friends are one of the main reasons why they can endure the harsh challenges that living in the wild country presents to them. As their small civilization is threatened by a natural disaster, the town's community supports itself by supporting every citizen—an approach that would be much more difficult in a massive city.



Anna thinks that they all must be mad as she, Luke, and the Watts play six games of tennis under the churning, smoky sky. When they're all too exhausted to play anymore, they go home to shower, then they meet again on the headland to watch the fire's progress. After seeing the burning sandhills and noticing a plume of smoke on the horizon that wasn't there yesterday, they head home again and wait to see what happens. Luke works on his laptop, but Anna feels restless and jittery, feeling like she needs a manual task to keep her mind occupied. That afternoon, the sky turns grayish yellow as the wind picks up, and a strange light descends on Garra Nalla. Anna still feels nervous as the house and the garden are shaken by the howling winds.

The purpose of this sequence is mostly to build the dramatic tension. It's clear that the climax of the novel is approaching, and that whatever is about to happen will likely change Luke and Anna's lives significantly. Anna's earlier anxieties about the wind seem dwarfed in comparison to the disaster that might be about to unfold in Garra Nalla. But Luke and Anna have chosen to live in the wilderness, and the harshest possible consequence of that choice is now right at their doorstep.



Even Luke is frightened as the wind gets stronger. He tells Anna that he has to go back to the headland to see what's happening. He once again worries about Anna's breathing in the smoke, but she insists on going with him. After shielding her nose, mouth, and eyes with a scarf and sunglasses, Anna and Luke stagger up to the headland. Many of the other townspeople (including Gil and Alan) are already gathered to watch the blaze while shielding their eyes. An explosive firestorm has developed in the distance, and the onlookers watch in shock as faraway houses and trees burst and incinerate. They watch for an hour, and several townspeople use rakes to keep flammable material away from the fiery projectiles flinging towards the town.

Eventually, Gil points towards the horizon and tells everyone that the wind has changed direction; it's no longer blowing towards Garra Nalla. As they watch the burning sandhills, they see the fire struggling to move towards them, and Gil remarks that maybe the worst of the firestorm is behind them. This seems to be the case, but Alan and Luke point out that they should nonetheless stay and keep watching, just in case. Just then, Bette points to the north and shouts for everyone to look in that direction. A massive smoke cloud, surging with flames, is headed right for them. As Gil starts to wonder how it moved up the coast so quickly, the cloud emits a searing fireball that sets a canopy of brush aflame. Immediately, the group scatters and runs.

Alan yells to Bette, telling her to take the kids down to the beach where they'll be safer from the fire. Luke tells Anna to go with Bette, but Anna refuses as the two of them sprint through the smoke towards their house. After rushing in through the backdoor, they quickly scramble for wool clothes in the bedroom. Luke considers putting on his favorite heavy sweater, but he decides against it and tosses it onto the bed. Meanwhile, Anna submerges towels in the full bathtub and rolls them up into tight, wet ropes that can be jammed against the doors. As Anna rushes out into the garden to join Luke, a fireball begins to consume the yard with incredible suddenness. Luke yells for Anna to get back in the house. They both rush inside and slam the door behind them as the flames crackle and rage through the garden.

Luke and Anna were comforted and distracted by their tennis game with the Watts earlier, but now the entire town of Garra Nalla has shown up to help each other. The town banding together demonstrates the power of community more strongly than anywhere else in the novel. But the approaching bushfire is still an unsettling presence, and it seems frighteningly possible that the community's efforts won't be enough. While Garra Nalla is a very small community, it's still a civilization in its own right, and nature may decide to reclaim it.



This sudden incident is the tipping point that launches the novel into its climax. Despite the community's best efforts to maintain a sense of control, the citizens of Garra Nalla have no choice but to flee when faced with such a powerful natural disaster hitting their town. Nature has fully invaded this tiny civilization at this point, making the next few minutes a game of survival—a matter of life and death. Luke and Anna fled the city to live close to nature, but now nature has come to them in its full, destructive force.



Anna's worst fears seem to come true as the firestorm reaches the house itself, putting both her and Luke in serious danger. Her garden is seemingly destroyed in this moment, representing the complete collapse of her emotional barriers during this harrowing experience. Now more than ever, nature is testing the limits of Luke and Anna's willingness to live in the country rather than the safety of the city. Meanwhile, the significance of Luke's decision to leave his favorite wool sweater behind will become clear later on.



Horried, Luke and Anna watch the flames outside, realizing that there's likely no safe means of escape. They soon hear the sound of a fire truck as it swiftly backs into their garden. A fireman jumps from the truck and yells at the couple to climb in. With Luke and Anna in tow, the truck speeds out of the burning yard in the nick of time. The truck stops by the lagoon, where many of the townsfolk are already taking refuge in the water. After thanking the firemen, who only showed up at the house by sheer luck, Luke and Anna waded into the lagoon themselves. Anna's thoughts race as she wonders if anything is left of their house. Luke asks if she's alright, and she testily answers yes, knowing that anger is the only emotion that will get her through this crisis.

Luke and Anna look around for Gil and Alan as they listen to the distant roar of the fire, but with no luck. After night falls, a police car pulls up to the lagoon. A man with a megaphone steps out and tells the townsfolk that they'll be given dry clothes and taken to a nearby church to spend the night. He explains that they can't return to their homes because the entire town has become a possible crime scene. The police will be looking for signs of arson, even though the townsfolk know for certain that it was just a particularly bad firestorm.

At the church, the people of Garra Nalla rest on many mattresses strewn about the floor of the large hall. Anna sees a limping and singed old woman walk by, telling a fireman that she can't blink without it hurting. Relief workers provide supper for everyone, but Luke only takes one bite of his sandwich before his adrenaline wears off and he falls into an exhausted slumber. Anna watches him lovingly, thinking of how typical this is; Luke really could sleep anywhere. She lies awake for a while before dozing off, but the cry of a baby in the hall wakes her, and her arm brushes a child by her side. She realizes with overwhelming relief that it's the boy, who's returned to her at last. She watches him sleep and caresses him, murmuring to herself that she knew he was indestructible.

While the fortunate arrival of the firemen was a massive relief, Anna is still as far as she can be from calming down. Her snappy reply to Luke is a sign that she's hiding her overwhelming fear and panic with anger. She's deeply afraid that she and Luke have already lost their new house, but both of them have effectively suppressed their more vulnerable emotions throughout the novel. Regardless, the firestorm has pushed them to their limits, and now it will likely become harder for them to ignore the feelings they've been hiding from themselves.



The police suspecting that the fire might have been the result of arson emphasizes just how destructive the firestorm was. It also confirms what Gil has been implying throughout the novel: people outside of Garra Nalla's community don't know the first thing about the place. While the police investigate possible arson, the townspeople know that the firestorm was just a natural disaster, as they saw it take shape with their own eyes. This sharpens the contrast between Garra Nalla and the outside world, but it also highlights how the town's community can easily take care of itself without outside intervention.



While the effect that the firestorm had on the people of Garra Nalla is rendered in saddening detail, the town's community continues to stick together after the disaster. The solemn atmosphere of this moment highlights the townspeople's care for each other and seems to imply that the worst is over. It's notable that the boy finally returns to Anna during this time of quiet and rest. Without any distractions or emotional barriers left standing, Anna is free to reunite with the child she feared she'd lost. But despite how comforted Anna feels, the boy still seems to be a phantom or hallucination that appears only to Anna and Luke. This implies that something is still wrong in their world—something that needs to be settled once and for all when the smoke clears.



In the morning, a constable informs the townspeople that they're lucky: the fire somehow only destroyed three houses in all of Garra Nalla. He explains that two unoccupied shacks and one family's house were claimed by the fire, but the rest of the houses are intact. Luke and Anna can hardly believe this until they see the house for themselves, surrounded by the charred remains of the garden but still standing. Inside, a thin layer of ashes covers everything, and Luke notices a dead **bird** in the middle of the floor. He realizes that this is the same owl-like bird that stared at him some time ago. Anna is surprised and exasperated to see how upset Luke gets over this bird's passing. She finds herself feeling angry with him again; after all they've been through, why is he upset by this one bird?

Just as Anna is about to take a shower and get rid of all the filth from the fire so she can think more clearly, she notices something in the bedroom. Luke's favorite wool sweater, which he had left sitting on the bed, has a black hole in it. She realizes that an ember must have blown in during the firestorm and landed on the sweater, where it burned itself out without setting the sheets (and the house) ablaze. Anna almost feels like crying, but she's too tired and doesn't have the energy. Just then, she hears Luke calling for her. She finds him on the veranda, watching Gil raking charred embers away in his yard.

Luke and Anna immediately pay Gil a visit, and he cheerfully confirms that the Watts were evacuated to a nearby town, and that they're probably back in Garra Nalla by now. In fact, no one in Garra Nalla died during the blaze. Somehow, the little town survived an incredible firestorm. Alan later describes the fear he felt as he clung to rocks on the beach as the fire approached. He was afraid that his kids would get swept away into the ocean, so he was really more afraid of the water than the fire in that moment. Gil confirms that "it's all different when your kids are with you," and acknowledges that they were all relying on pure luck, even the children.

That evening, Luke leaves the house without telling Anna. He walks in an area of nature reserve nearby, where the fire scorched everything in sight, leaving no plant life intact. As he wanders in this desolate place full of ashes and charred remains, he weeps as he's mentally transported back to a terrible day two years ago in the hospital delivery room. Anna had just had a miscarriage, and the broken landscape around Luke reminds him of the pale, lifeless body of their unborn son. On that dark day in the hospital, a counsellor asked them if they wanted to name the boy. Numbly, they agreed, as it seemed like the right thing to do. But in the end, they only ever thought of him as "the boy," as this felt somehow more intimate.

Despite the relief Luke and Anna feel when they see their house is unharmed, the dead bird on their floor feels like another omen—a sign that something important still needs to be resolved. In any case, it's implied that Luke isn't mourning the bird itself. Whether he knows it or not, he's thinking of something else that's grieving him. The strange sense of happiness he felt when he first stared at the owl-like bird has been replaced with a dismaying sight that brings him sharply back to reality. Even though the disaster spared the house, the sight of the dead bird is a reminder that nature and civilization are still at odds. And, as usual, a dead bird signifies that change might not be possible for Luke and Anna, even despite the catastrophe they just survived.



The realization that Luke's sweater might have saved the house almost forces Anna to face her emotions—but not quite. She's still flustered and distracted by the nightmarish events of the previous day, but an underlying sense of unease and unresolved grief remains. Gil's survival is another distraction, but a very welcome one. Luke and Anna's deep concern for Gil is a sign that they've truly become a part of Garra Nalla's community and that they care for their neighbors.



The fact that Garra Nalla survived the firestorm with no casualties once again reinforces how effective a small community can be when it comes to protecting their own. Nonetheless, the natural disaster still shook the townspeople deeply, as Alan's reaction demonstrates. Garra Nalla learned what it truly means to be at the mercy of the elements as their small civilization was threatened by nature like never before. Alan's fear of losing his children reflects Anna's own anxiety about the boy abandoning her. Between her, Gil, and now Alan, the fear of grief and loss affects nearly every major character in the novel.



At long last, the truth about the boy is revealed through this flashback. The boy is only an imaginary projection of what Luke and Anna imagine their son would have been like if he had survived the birth. This tragic fact has been heavily implied throughout the novel, but now it's revealed beyond doubt. It makes sense to reveal the truth now, as this is the first time Luke has allowed himself to really think about Anna's miscarriage since the beginning of the novel. The firestorm has swept through the area and left desolation in its wake, but the sight of nature's destruction is ultimately what leads Luke to acknowledge his grief.



The sweater that Luke left on the bed was the sweater he had worn on another day he wanted to forget. He had worn it on a cold day when he and Anna cast the ashes of their unborn child into the sea. Luke left the sweater behind during the firestorm because he didn't want it to be damaged, and because it reminded him of the son they never had. But by leaving the sweater on the bed, Luke likely (though unknowingly) saved their house. If that lone ember had landed on the bedsheets instead of fizzling out on the wool sweater, the house would most likely have burned down.

As Luke takes his walk, Anna nervously wonders where he could be. Bette guesses that he might be shell-shocked like Alan, who still stares out to sea as he processes what happened. Anna also tries calling her mother and telling her that Luke is nowhere to be found, but Anna is annoyed by how indifferent her mother sounds on the phone. Later that evening, Luke finally walks up the driveway in tears. Anna asks him if it's that bad, realizing she's never seen him cry before. Luke shakes his head and says he isn't upset about the fire. She asks if it's the boy, and he nods silently, standing still. She embraces him, and they stand in the doorway holding each other for a long time.

That night, Anna dreams of the boy waving in an open doorway. This is unusual, as the boy has never visited her in her dreams before. In her dream, she sees him waving in a perfect version of her garden, before the fire destroyed it. Before she has a chance to wave back, the boy dissolves into the sunlight. She wakes from the dream with tears in her eyes, and she cries silently for quite some time. Eventually, she stops crying and lies on her back, staring up into the darkness with dry eyes.

In late December, the citizens of Garra Nalla gather for a large picnic to celebrate the survival of their town. Many of the townsfolk are still in shock or traumatized by the crisis, but Bette insists on having a party so the children can see that the adults are fine. Anna finds herself in a happy, drunken haze at the gathering, and she admires the men of the town speaking intimately with each other as she watches them. She tells herself that she's ready to give life another try, as she can't delay decisions forever. After all, if she waits too long, there might not be a future to live in.

Luke's flashback continues and gives more context for the grief that he and Anna have been hiding throughout the novel. The flashback also explains just how unlikely and miraculous it was that Luke left his sweater on the bed. In a way, it's almost as if the couple's unborn child saved their house. This comforting thought makes it even easier for Luke to finally come to terms with the pain of his loss after distracting himself from it for so long.



The couple's embrace is the culmination of their long struggle with suppressing their grief. For the entire novel, they've silently imagined their boy alongside them, almost pretending that they really had a child. But now that Anna's miscarriage is finally out in the open, they can reckon with their feelings and begin to heal. Anna almost immediately understood why Luke was crying when he came home, which implies that both of them were always aware of their shared grief, always lingering in the back of their minds. Evidently, a terrifying firestorm was drastic enough to break down their emotional walls and force them to face reality together.



In this dream, Anna takes time to herself to grieve for the boy she never had. Her embrace of Luke was a healthy first step, but grief is a long process that takes time to run its course—both in company and in solitude. Anna has hesitated to cry throughout the novel, but now she's finally facing her emotions, and it's changing her for the better. This is reinforced by the fact that the boy has never shown up in her dreams before. She still sees him, but in a different way; things have changed at last.



Garra Nalla's community comes together one last time, confirming that they're stronger and closer than ever following the firestorm. Such a traumatic event would be difficult for any one person to bear alone, so the community functions as a healthy support network for all of the townspeople. This includes Anna, who's already showing signs of personal growth. Surrounded by a supportive community and emboldened by her emotional progress, it's no surprise that she feels ready to start her life anew.



As these thoughts occur to Anna, she spots the boy in a skiff in the lagoon, paddling out to sea. She understands that he's finally leaving them for good, but she feels ready to accept it. She waves goodbye and silently thanks him for staying with them for so long. At this moment, Bette happily points out that the black **swans** have returned to the lagoon. They haven't been seen since the fire, and it seemed possible that they had flown away permanently. As the men look up to hear this joyful news, Anna waves to Luke and he waves back.

Anna's goodbye to the boy marks the completion of her character arc. She was afraid to lose the boy throughout the novel, but now she willingly lets him leave for good. This demonstrates how much her experiences have changed her, now that she's brought her grief into the light of day. By waving goodbye to the boy, she finally accepts that her unborn son is gone and that she can still live a full and happy life without him. It's what the boy would want for her, after all. The arrival of the swans confirms that hope has returned to Anna's life. Her life changing for the better is no longer just a possibility; it looks like a certainty.



That night, Luke dreams of many kinds of **birds**. He groans in his sleep as he tries to see the mysterious owl-like bird: the bird he still doesn't know the name of. Anna brushes her teeth and throws away a packet of pills as she gets ready for bed, but she doesn't feel tired yet. She resolves to make some toast and watch the nightly news until falling asleep. Anna looks out the window and sees that somehow, some of her she-oaks in the garden were untouched by the flames. She listens to the eerie sound of the wind whispering through the leaves, remembering how it felt to go canoeing with Luke and the boy. Turning away from the window, Anna lies on the couch, picks up the remote, and flips the television on.

Even with so many signs of positive change on the horizon, the novel still ends on a somewhat ambiguous note. On one hand, Anna has clearly begun to move on and heal from her grief, as she throws away her medication and seems at peace with her inner world. But at the same time, Luke's uneasy dreams of birds he can't name seems like an unresolved question, and Anna's final action of the novel has a hint of irony to it. Watching the news is a habit she's maintained since she was a teenager. This makes the novel's ending a stark contrast to the opening, which describes Luke taking up a brand-new hobby of birdwatching. This might imply that some things can never change. The novel has a hopeful ending overall, but grief takes time to process. Luke and Anna's lives go on, but subtle uncertainties still linger in the air, like the whispering of the she-oaks outside.





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